Man With the Skies

1

It was on a moment's notice that was running on the radio as the car made the curve. It had rained the previous night. And the car, although in good condition, showed signs of wear and tear. The driver did not seemed to be bothered by this; if anything, he whistled to the tune of the song running on the radio. "It was truly a dark and stormy night". He held the steering wheel with both hands, and controlled the car's speed with the clutch and gear.

The inside composed of leather seats, floor mats, and the car's so called "cock-pit". this portion was in less clean conditions than the rest of the car, only because of the cups attached on top of one another. It had been a long drive, and with the clearing road ahead of him - "why do people say empty road when they clearly always state that the coast is clear?" was the thought running in his mind - he gave the indicator and took the turning for the hotel. It passed through a boulevard, where trees swayed to the rustling of the wind. The road, even with the steadily increasing fog, did not lead him astray: he slowed his car steadily, at the gate where the plaque read "Niner Hotel". He opened a khaki colored folder, took out a tri folded brochure/envelope, opened it, and held out a piece of paper in his hand. After placing a hazard indicator, he stepped out of the car and walked to the booth marked "check-in".

2

"Your good name please:, to wit, the response was noted and shared with the check-in booth. The car made its way through the lush green, fairly moist front yard of the Niner, in the direction of the entrance of the hotel. He handed the car to the valet, and climbed the stairs. "Where are you lovely princesses, who were mentioned in the brochure?" he asked himself, as he turned to and for. With an "Ah!" he made his way to the reception. "Welcome to the Niner hotel, where... you seem to have been a regular of ours, always a pleasure... We made a few changes to the hotel even if it seems that the Niner looks the same as your father described... spoken like a true Niner, well... here are the details of your room, and also... ah, great; enjoy your stay here, elevators are at the left atrium."

The guest walked to the elevators, holding his briefcase and hotel keys. He was given company by the tapping sound which his shoes made as they made contact with the freshly polished granite floor. From where he stood, it looked like a painting; it was boring, and reminded of how long the elevator took to arrive to its relevant floor. Upon entering, he found that it had been full of air, giving off a cold aura. It wasn't in fact the case; The elevator stopped at the required floor, from where the guest made his way to his room. "Aye, mist... that view indeed." he said, looking at the fog over the lake.

3

he sat on the bed, taking in the view. He had brought with him his briefcase, a backpack and a box handed to him by the hotel, by the bellboy some time back, and had placed it on the suitcase table. He took the box from the suitcase table and tossed it on the bed. He had not given it much thought, nor had he unpacked his things yet. His disposition, his demeanor, his thoughts, were calm. "Plenty of time to use, and yet no time at all" was written on the caption of one of the paintings hanging in the room. It was just above the study-table, on which was placed a vanilla colored envelope, an empty set of paper sheets, a pencil, a bowl with complimentary erasers, another bowl with complementary sharpeners, a laminated paper on which was, in bold, written.

"ERASERS AND SHARPNERS WILL BE PROVIDED UPON REQUEST: CONSERVE WATER. YOU SPILL IT, WE BILL IT!"

"Why bill the water when there is a lake nearby?" he thought, as he got up to check the drawers of the study desk. He found a notepad with the same number as the serial code on the box. the telephone was placed by his bedside; a brief conversation ensued, after which he put the notepad in his pocket. His jacket already had a pen in it; just in case he also took a pencil, some erasers, and a sharpener. He opened his briefcase and put a few articles on the bed. These included a map, which he crumbled and put in the trash bin; a few flyers, which he discarded; a mini review which had been littered with red ink, from which he kept the third page and discarded the other five.

4

It - the briefcase - was a modest article. It had some papers but mostly it was empty. It did have some significant qualities for astute observers. It was an inheritance, as the mark on the front insignia had some similarities to a school near the Niner. While it was mahogany colored, the briefcase was made of studier stuff - an alternate perspective would suggest that it had been underutilized, with evidence pinpointing to the state of his backpack. On one corner was a slight chipping, the exception to an otherwise well cared for piece of equipment.

he took out a letter from the briefcase, and placed it on the desk. The briefcase was placed in one of the closet drawers. He then opened his backpack, from which a significant variety of materials and relevant miscellany was littered on the bed. He first assorted them in an orderly fashion; he then placed them in their relevant places in the room. Once the backpack was emptied, he hid it under his bed. He was about to start reading the letter, when the telephone rang again. he picked it up, and heard the request from the reception desk.

"Yes, Homaiz, connect her please."

he noticed that the fog had become noticeably thicker, even though the wind had slowed down significantly. The rustling had stopped as well.

5

The call got transferred, after which a series of questions were asked, as well as the assortment of reminders from a time long past. "There is a lovely restaurant here which is facing the lake. In case you have time to spare, do be sure to visit. Be sure to also give a call, and we will be sure to join you there as well." They shared mutual greetings at which point he hung up the phone, and looked at the letter on the desk. It was a handwritten personal piece, about ten pages long: the paper which was used had a slightly rough bout regular texture, and smelt of vanilla and strawberries. "I should order chocolate milk for myself." he thought ,as he started the first paragraph. The fog seemed to have shifted away from the lake, as he took in the view of the lake. There was a small pier as well, but it seemed to have been blocked by a board and some obstacles, where he had originally taken the notepad. He got up, took out the jacket from the closet, picked up the hotel keys, and left the room, locking it from behind.

The elevator played a song to which he whistled along; the ding marked the arrival at the lobby floor of the hotel. He stepped out of the elevator, deciding to explore - more specifically, wander - around the

hotel. The ends of either side of the hotel had noticeably long corridors, with the structure of the roof lending it an air of awe and amazement. he had read somewhere that this optical illusion was deliberate.

6

He looked around the hotel and found a signpost, where he found this information. To him, it was an action performed to keep himself busy. He decided to continue walking forward, where he saw a staircase leading downwards. On the wall was posted "B2 for swimming and listening to the sound of water flowing past the land." He decided to turn left, where he saw a few shops selling a variety of items. They did not particularly catch his attention, although he raised his eyebrows when he noticed that they had procured from a vendor specific to these parts and that he seemed to know this person. "He may still be in town" was one of the thoughts he had as he headed back towards the lobby. He walked towards the opposite direction, this time he found a coffee shop owner, a chocolate shop owner, and a bread maker walking into a bar... "I don't think the joke went that way" he thought to himself.

The signpost stated that the morning was dedicated to yoga classes while there were music rooms available for afternoon relaxation and consideration. He was half expecting a piano to start playing but there was only the sound of feet and the sound of an activity taking place. One of the conference rooms was open, with the noise of a vacuum cleaner running in the background. He made his way back to the lobby.

7

"The fog has ended, now if you would... I see, well, he is there."

He took note of the directions of the shop, and after thanking Homaiz, he walked out. He made slow and steady strides in some direction, knowing that inevitably he will find a shop and then he could ask the shopkeeper something, if need be. The sound of rustling leaves and wind blowing made way to a droning sound which was difficult to describe. Considering that there was a wide road on which he was walking, it did not seem bizarre that there were that many cars in the area. The fog also did not pay it much heed, passing to and for in a leisurely fashion.

He kept walking until he came across a Y section. Both routes did not have any signposts, although their relative width and spread did indicate that they were heading to town. he heard the sound of a horn from the distance, and was followed by laughter. "The Qin is going to put those boys in a tough spot" he thought. He decided to take the turning. He walked straight, making a curve with the road as the road curved. As he made his way downwards from the road - the curve was more of a downward spiral, however, it was not so steep - he found that the fog had become thicker. He kept his pace, and continued on his path. The scent of water beating with wood marked the indicator he needed to confirm his suspicions; he continued to walk onward.

8

He found himself making his way into an elongated pavement. There were numerous shops on either side, stretched to a distance, joined in part by a raised and boundary protected walkway made of wood. he found a number of shops, some of which seemed familiar. He stopped walking when he reached the stairs of four shops which were neighboring each other.

the leftmost shop had a number of items which he could not see, and the signpost on the front was as if it had been engrained onto the wooden panel. The shop neighboring it on the right had a vase like bucket, from which protruded a number of flowers. he could make out some colored ones, but they seemed to blend into one another since the fog flowed through them. The name of the shop was written cursive and was blocked partially by the roof, which was slanted to keep the small in shadows for a seat whenever there was a summer day. The shop neighboring the flower-shop had an unassuming double door entrance, and a simple signpost which read "Elias' gift shop and general store" in that exact format. The shop neighboring Elias had a long paper attached to the window and was seemingly barred.

He walked up to the shop's walkway and started from the leftmost shop. the sign was not discernable although he could make out words from it: "School store". The flower-shop was titled "Tabitha's Flower shop: with ;complimentary' written on the bucket. He entered Elias' shop.

9

An elderly gentleman sat at the checkout point of the shop. He was facing the door, focusing his energies in cleaning a cup; Elias, it seemed, kept a variety of items with him. the cupboards had an assortment of porcelain table-sets, a set of books whose titles were obscured by the height at which they were placed; there were also some dolls placed on the top shelves, some of which had brief descriptions provided as notes stringed onto them. Perhaps he had ben noting one of the dolls very carefully, as after some time Elias asked him:

"Have you ever been to the Birtash?"

Elias took a sip from the cup of tea he had made. He nodded.

"That was a long time back, seems like an age past by."

Elias got up from his stool and stepped out of the checkout. He took out a stick which had a hook grafted onto one end. He took out some of the objects from the shelves, and after some time would return them to their place.

"Yes, quite a collection, but still has a long way to go before I can call it a complete collection."

Elias sighed and shook his head.

"There is... are... so many places to go, before I can be fully conclusive with what I have. I do wonder though... why are you so interested in it?"

Elias took a sip from his tea and had a Yivelis alongside.

He nodded and opened one of his drawers. "Why not start from there? See what the Qin has to say." said Elias.

10

He nodded and turned around to leave. "Happy to be of service" said Elias, to the sound of the door being opened.

the fellow looked at the complimentary flowers being offered, noting how they seemed vibrant even in the fog. "They do catch one's attention" he noted. He looked at the shop which was a neighbor to Elias, and remembered that it had a paper on the window. He read through all of it; it was a document of some level of importance. After finishing reading, he thought of something and walked out into the main road. Most of the area was as he had left it, although it was noticeably more ambient, the sound of the floorboards creaking, the soft tapping on the windows, and a sound of a music box in the distance were the only sounds which gave him company.

He whistled to himself, noting that as he headed in the direction of the school, the music box became more noticeable. "The owner has good taste". he thought to himself. He could see the boundaries of the institution from where he was standing. On the left there was presumably an empty space, as there was not much to see for quite a distance. As he looked right onward. There were a series of significant buildings, although they could not be identified as to what role they played. He kept looking, and the sound of boys playing games was very faintly audible. the sound of the music box had become noticeably quiet.

11

He took out the notepad and read through the notes for his points about the next stop. "How curious that I didn't color code where I am going" was one of the thoughts coming to his mind as he made his way from the road forward. he continued to where he had heard the sound of mischief. he continued forward and took a right turn from the second crossing; he turned right at the turning marked "Külzirtaak Road"; he crossed four buildings, and at the sight of a large building with an empty but vast courtyard facing it, he took out his notepad and then walked straight ahead, turned left took a flight of stairs downwards, and then followed the road to the right, and with the sound of the waves and some scuttling of feet, he kept his pace and continued moving forward. he zipped up his jacket as he made his way towards the place he had his mind set to go.

he noticed a couple, who were playing off into the distance. The features of the two were difficult to make or determine, and their voices also sounded vague and distant. it was clear they were fun at the beach, and seemed to be at peace, almost as if they had known each other for quite some time. Alongside the couple was a little boy, sitting on the picnic mat and quietly observing his parents but not participating himself - "a child left all alone at a beach is a monstrous idea indeed" he thought to himself. He couldn't" determine the child's features either.

12

He squinted for a while, as his path became somewhat blurry. The beach and the sound of the waves however, marked his being in the right direction. they were neither loud nor were they in any way dimming. It was a curving, flat, vague road which led somewhere. he felt he was making progress, since he could now feel the scent - "smell is as much as sense as every other: you feel it the same way you taste something, or see something. I was told that once." he heard these words being shared to an audience unnamed, and beyond his view - of sandwiches being served. They had the air of home to them... Even though these sandwiches were home baked and cooked since it was a picnic. "Food for

thought" he thought to himself, finding that the path started making an upward trajectory.

there was a sound of a bell slowly resonating from a distance. The sound of laughter, arguments, as well as mischief could be faintly heard from the background as well. He kept walking, finding the draft had left allowing him to open his jacket again. He moved in the direction of the sound. the road came to a stop, with a wall blocking a forward path. He looked left and right .He decided to move left. he kept going straight. he took the turning when the wall turned. He found a back-gate which he observed carefully. He retraced his steps and walked in the opposite direction. He took the turn after some time. he was greeted by the sight of a grand entrance. the gate was open, with a cemented path leading to the school.

13

He walked on the cemented path, up the flight of stairs, and knocked on the door... by pressing the bell on the wall marked "bell". He stepped back, hearing the sound of footsteps - loud, marked footsteps - from within the building. It took a while for the door to open, but it was an intense duration of waiting.

The door opened. An elderly gentleman looked out and was greeted as per custom, by the couple.
"We take pride in him" they said. the elderly gentleman offered his hand to the applicant being discussed. He shook it, in what can best be summarized as a neutral way of shaking hands: there was just enough force to show acknowledgement but not enough to imply endearment - one could not make an opinion from it.

the couple then cheered their son, and informed him that they will come to pick him up before lunch. When he was inside the school, the Qin smiled and described it to him. "My father used to love walking in this hallway" he said, as he led him up a flight of stairs to the first floor, left towards the fifth room in the general direction of the teacher staff room. There were plenty of chairs and tables laid in an orderly fashion in the room. "You will be attended to, in a while" the Qin said, to which he responded to the Qin: "Very well, sir".

"Laraiez, if you must address me" responded the Qin.

14

He looked at the whiteboard. To his left was a view of the playground where the sound of activity was at play. the room itself was full of an assortment of school projects, and lessons learnt by everyone who had passed through the same halls and system, the same way he did. He took note of what the students had been busy with. He took note of one particular project, in which a group had apparently been able to create a fascinating wonder out of ordinary objects.

He took his seat again, as the bell rang. the students started pouring back in, taking their places accordingly. A teacher entered the class carrying with him an assortment of papers. he put them on his table, and after taking out some markers, he proceeded with the lesson of the day. "Rawel Kenpel, what does water do to it?: He asked the teacher. to this, a lot of diagrams were drawn and an even bigger lot of words were spoken. He nodded to all this and thanked the teacher, quietly trying to make sense of this knowledge. "Papa would know about it, I suppose." he thought to himself.

The day droned on in the same usual variety of events, often described as "ufts" by the students. It was a reference to the sound which students used to make, apparently, when a spectacular sort of failure happened, or if a variety of assignments had been given to be completed in a short duration. Even if these assignments were achievable, it was considered a pointless exercise, since it was more reasonable to make a physical copy of the assignment and rewrite it on a new set of pages.

15

He walked into the hallway, noting the various sounds being made as he walked into the direction of his locker. There was a variety of sounds, yet he could not describe them in the same way his friends could. He just knew that sounds were being made, and then just carried forward to his purpose. "Would it make sense for water to be made the way it is?" he asked himself, as he opened his locker and put his things inside. he walked downstairs to the entrance and waited on one of the seats. his father had informed him that he will be picked up some time before lunch. he waited, neither eager nor worried, neither fearful - there is nothing to fear, so his father would say - nor ecstatic. He simply thought of it as one more activity to mark the end of the day.

He had been looking carefully at the project, once more wondering about it. however, he did not get any answers from his investigation. He left the room and took the flight of stairs downwards. When he reached the ground floor he walked right and kept going straight. there were a few labs to his left and right, where people would have been working, yet it seemed as if only students were busy inside. he kept continuing straight, and took little heed of the noisy library, and the quiet room marked "debate club". After a walk which seemed like an eternity but was practically a simple stroll, he saw the office of the Qin. he knocked on the door, and waited for a response.

The Qin opened the door, and nodded. Laraiez let him in, and closed the door upon his entering. Laraiez bid him to take a seat, Laraiez offered tea, to which a decline was presented. Laraiez and made tea for himself, ringing a bell and asking a staff if they could bring some Yivelis.

16

"Before your father will arrive, I was hoping that you and I could have a discussion about a matter of grave concern." Laraiez said, hoping to proceed without interruption while at the same time indulging in tea dipped Yivelis. Both of these wishes were granted. Whilst the discussion was proceeding, he looked out of the window and observed the view. The sound of leaves rustling, the wind blowing, and the distant flowing of water from a distance. He thought to himself if Laraiez could hear that water flowing, but kept quiet as Laraiez was busy with his lecture.

Laraiez had lowered his glasses and asked him "I heard that you had wanted to avoid playing sports in order to spend more time at the library. Is that true?" To this, Laraiez was given a positive response. Laraiez asked a few more questions, and was promptly answered. There had been a debate on some of the answers between Laraiez and him, but these were purely to determine the dedication of his decision. He had stayed in school after school-hours as he had been asked by Laraiez for this discussion. Laraiez nodded when he was informed about the application that had also been submitted.

When his father arrived, Laraiez had the gentleman seated outside his office and then, with his son, came to greet the person. they had some small talk regarding how children will always do as they please. "I'll inform Punbell about your son. he would appreciate the help" said Laraiez. he was taken aback not so much by the Qin giving permission, but by his father; his father shook hands with Laraiez, immeasurably proud of his son being given such an opportunity. they shared one more greeting and then departed.

17

He waited for the arrival of Laraiez. After a certain time had passed, he got up and walked out of the office. He walked straight ,and in the middle of the hall, he turned right. He walked down the hall to the open doors, where he looked out into a school playground. Unlike the one he had passed through when entering the school, this one had a number of gardens broken by numerous pathways. These pathways were composed of granite slabs, of square shape, placed in a manner that all the patches of grass looked like the same area, shape, and consistency. There were portions in which seating areas had been marked: benches with a canopy to provide sheds. He always wondered whether the fees rising in their school had to do with maintaining this part of the school., of if there had actually been a series of unfortunate events which led to this happening.

He turned around and went back to the entrance of the school, and turned towards the playground. He took a stroll around it, noting that it was not yet free-time to play with all the toys in the playground. Some of the swings looked like they had been used often, to which he saw some scribbles on the base. He kept strolling around, accompanied by distant sounds of words which were being spoken but could not be heard clearly. Amidst this sound was also the creaking of metal, which he could see the source of, but not clearly.

He took out his notepad, and looked at some of his scribbles. He put the notepad back, and felt his pockets. He made his way out of the school, nodding.

18

> "He whistled a song as he made his walk in a general direction. Most of his walk seemed to be pedestrian, with a noticeable increase in the fog as he made his walk onward. "Whistle me a lullaby" he hummed and whistled, as he made his way onwards. He couldn't clearly distinguish what lay ahead of him, and as he walked forward the trekking distance covered became consumed"

"I'll find out where I read that segment from" he noted to himself quietly as he made his way from the school back to the road. Much like the section, he noticed that the fog had increased in thickness, although it was noticeably more quiet. The family who had been at the beach seemed to have gone in another place. Or not. The sound of the water gave a very calming feeling as it struck the sand. He remembered as he walked, something which he had thought of and considered whilst at the school. He found after some time, that he was near to the pavement leading to Elias' shop. He entered the shop.

"You look like a century old joke being sold to a clueless child" commented Elias, as he cleaned some cups. He had an opened box near the counter. After placing the cup on one of the shelves, he took out one of the dolls from the opened box, and observed it very meticulously. "Are you thinking what I am thinking" Elias asked him, whilst turning the doll too and fro. Elias did not need to get a response -

neither in words, nor in gesture. "So I am the only one thinking it" said Elias, and put the doll in a box and hid it under his counter.

19

Elias looked at him and asked whilst he took out some more dolls: "I heard that you started working at the library". Most of the dolls which Elias took out from the box were hand-made, and had small notes included with each one provided separately. They were varied in length - some of them were only two sentences long, others tended to be at least two paragraphs. Their quality, however, was uniform: they explained where the dolls had been hand-sown and what manufacturing quality standards were followed. "So I heard; Lebrius Punbell should come over to my shop from time to time. Do let him know next time you get to meet him." He heard Elias say as he entered the shop.

Upon entering, Elias tapped him on the shoulder and offered him a box. "As an offering from me to Punbell. Just share those words with him when you meet him, he will understand what I am referring to." he took the box from Elias and left the shop. He saw some of the flowers were being taken from Tabitha's. He hastened his way in the direction of Punbell, preoccupied at the moment to note who the buyer was.

The fog was thickest as he left the street towards the main road but slowly became less thick after some time. It was being referred in the radio as well. "Where does the lonely road go" was among the better known songs which would have radio play, and yet it would always run from the middle - the chorus - rather than the beginning. He whistled the chorus to himself as he walked onwards.

20

On the way, he noticed that a barrier separated him from another road.

He remembered his homework, and decided to take that opportunity to finish it. His father was doing something with the car and let him know that all was safe and under control. He stepped out of the car, opened the trunk and took out his bag. He noticed that there was a toolkit in one corner. He also took that out and offered it to his father. The response was lukewarm. "Just be sure to remind me that we have to take the toolbox back with us. That would be nice." His father requested him. He stepped back into the car whilst his father looked into the problem at hand.

He opened his book, and with a pencil, filled in all the answers that were being asked. By the time he got his final answer, his father - it seems - had been quietly poking his shoulder softly, as a nudge from a concerned parent rather than an angry teacher. He - looking at his father - noticed that they were at a different building rather than the school which he was used to. "I'll pick you up before lunch. Look, Punbell is out waiting for us right now" his father said, as he and his father stepped out of the car. He took out his bag and walked alongside his father. He then offered his hand to Punbell.

There was a brief discussion between his father and Punbell, and then his father left. He looked at Punbell, who pointed at the library and quietly walked inside. He looked around at the entrance of the library and found he was the first one there.

21

He was overwhelmed by the site. The sight of so much paper bound into a cover and then put into towers and towers of classified and categorized columns, each numbered as a tower. The sheer volume alone would have made a lesser man run away. Punbell, walking in his typical determined yet mildly indifferent manner - a clipboard with lists was held by him on his left arm, quietly noting each tower block and the books in each one - gestured him to come forward. Using gestures he asked - in what could best be described as earnest professionalism - which of the books were present in the block. After listening to Punbell, he got up the ladder next to the tower and read aloud each book title to Punbell, starting from the rightmost corner at the topmost shelf, through to the leftmost corner at the bottom shelf.

He noted that each tower, although numbered, had a pattern. He used this pattern as he made his rounds with Punbell, helping in categorizing each book. The ones which were not present in the library were noted and he would then schedule a visit to them. Punbell - however- decided against sending him, making him continue the same set of steps as he was trained to do by Punbell.

Even though he was surrounded by an assortment of books, he did not actually take time out to pick a book and read it. He, however, had noticed people taking time to read through tomes without a care for time. He found Punbell sitting at his desk, working through his map and the list he had. He sat down in front of him, placed Elias' offering on the table, and quietly waited.

22

Punbell quietly looked at the numerous documents, and classifying them in his routine means. He noticed Punbell's box in the center of the table, which he had last noticed on the rightmost corner. Punbell lowered his gaze and observed the box carefully. Punbell held the box with both hands, placed it at the center-right, and then used gestures to inquire regarding the nature of this gift or offering. He nodded to the discussion which ensued, and to the message Elias had included with the offering.

Punbell smiles - which was something that lightened up the mood in the library - and shook his head. He opened up the box and, taking note of what had been offered, he placed it in one of the cupboards. Punbell had noticed him quietly looking in the direction of Towers 50 and 32. Punbell subtly took note of what had been keeping his eye diverted, and to his disappointment, it was boredom. Punbell shook his head in disappointment and walked up to him.

Punbell pointed at the towers and gestured him to bring a specific something from one of the towers, noting that the details of the last owner was missing in the files. He got up and walked up the stairs to Tower 40. He continued walking and kept his eyes fixed onto the shelves. He accidentally bumped into a little girl, and both of them fell back. They apologized to each other. Before he could go on his way, the girl offered her hand and said "My name is..." He tried to remember her name but it did not seem to register. He took out the book from the shelf and brought it down to Punbell.

23

"So you finally met Maira?: Punbell inquired, the intent of teasing hidden behind a very thick and opaque veneer of indifferent tonal blankness.

He looked at Punbell and wondered what he was referring to. Punbell looked back at him, confused, and gestured to the cause of his gaze. He shook his head, and continued with his errands. After some time, he met Punbell at his desk. They both had a cup of tea, making sure that the papers were at a distance from their official papers. He asked Punbell something, to which receipt of answer was acknowledged. Punbell gestured to the "Pending Tasks" box. He took out one paper from it and handed the document to Punbell. Punbell had finished his tea and, placing the utensils and china to a side-table, proceeded with his work. He took out his map and noted some details on it.

He observed Punbell, and considered his environment alongside. Most of the study tables were unoccupied, and the towers - once supplied to significant extents with books - now seemed to have lost their charm. They were still towering with books, and still were in good conditions, but lacked something. He asked Punbell... He was about to ask something but changed his mind. Punbell was quietly reading a newspaper since the pending tasks of the day had been completed. Punbell offered tea and Yivelis to him. He declined, and with a gesture left the library.

He walked out and looked at the road ahead. He noticed a pathway which led downwards to some place. He took that path, and followed it to find himself at the beach, with a vast view hidden away by the tides. It felt like the library: it seemed to exist and function.

24

The waves silenced any noise purely by the power of its fury. With each strike of the water on the beachhead, it felt as if the water was coming to life; to command the Earth in obeying the will of the water. It did not seem to have any effect on him. He looked out at the endless reach of the water. Amongst the books he had read, both in school and in the library, there were few discussions on the nature of the water. "They should have taken a sample of the water and done something with it." He thought to himself, and not thinking that he was being clever.

He decided to take off his shoes and walked in the direction of the water. He noted the tides of the water and, keeping his distance, he stepped and waited by the beachhead. He felt the water course through the sand, embracing his feet and his knees. The water was mild - not so cold to make him shiver, not so hot it would have scalded his skin. He watched the water and the waves, moving when a stronger wave was about to touch the beachhead.

He heard the sound of feet scuttling through the sand, like a crunch being made at a regular rhythm. He turned around to notice a girl, gently walking but finding it difficult to do so. He gestured her to try walking without her shoes. She followed his advice, and smiled at him. "I forgot to introduce myself. My name is Maira" she said, and offered her hand to him. He simply nodded, and turned to look at the water again.

25

"Don't worry, I won't run you over." Maira giggled,and offered her hand again. He nodded, shook hands and gave a cursory smile. He kept quiet and gestured towards the waves. Maira nodded, tipped her hat, and she walked along in her own path. He stood at the water, and wondered about the nature of the water. He wondered where did all this water actually come from. He wondered where did it cease to be.

For as long as he could remember, the beach had always been there. The water had always been there. There were complete celebrations on this very beach which he had heard about when he was young. Although they never included what actually "happened" in these beaches.

He noticed that Maira was sitting near the sand that was dry and was observing the water while reading a book. He turned around, and walked towards a shower stand. He washed his feet meticulously, as well as the sand which was stuck on his knees. He remembered the warning in the Niner. He turned to find a symbolic counter to it; a series of instructions which explained, step by step, on how to clean up one's feet and skin after coming back from the beach. "He must have been hired by someone special to develop this" was one of the thoughts he had whilst reading these instructions. He took one of the towels from the rack, sat down, and dried his feet and knees.

He walked back on the road leading to the library and headed down from the road, where the fog became thicker and caused visibility to be limited. He thought of something and whilst whistling he noted it in his notepad.

26

He looked back at the notes he had made whilst writing, and continued to whistle as he made his written thoughts clear. He heard a horn from one side of the road, heading in the direction of the library. He couldn't make out who was driving, but he noted that the boy sitting on the passenger seat was much more quiet than his general nature. It had a certain degree of nostalgia to it, which he could not put into words. He noted it and continued to walk downwards from the hilly road. "Seems like a natural way to go" he thought to himself.

Elias had just opened a box of Yivelis, and offered it to him. "You might as well have some. You sound like a scientist who discovered what our water is composed of" Elias advised, and took note of what had been described in the notepad. Elias nodded, and answered with foresight, "There may perhaps be an answer to be found at the house in the middle of the street. It is not that far from there. The kid and you might have a lot more in common than you think." Elias took one Yivelis, and dipped it in his tea. He looked at the shelves in Elias' store, finding that they looked the same, in a different sort of way. He noted it in his thoughts.

He got up to walk out of the shop. Before he left, he looked at Elias. Elias pondered with his tea, and after pointing his finger towards the sky in a revelation, he took out a box, and gave him a book. "The kid had asked me to reserve it for his summer break. You should ask him about it when you two meet up." Elias explained to him, and Elias waved goodbye. He left the shop, with thoughts about the purple flower having limited importance to him.

27

He decided to walk further in the opposite direction, noticing that a few more shops had opened up in that direction. The road seemed a little bit on the wider side: there was a grander thoroughfare. The shops had more space and even had a deeper number of gullies between them. He could hear lots of chants and joyous music but it felt distant. "Let it go; they could have fun, that isn't why I'm here" he emphasized in his mind, slowly and steadily walking along the grid of the shops; he took a right from one of the stores and continued to walk straight until he saw a turning marked "To the Birtash tents".

He went the opposite direction.

He found a house which had been perfectly fenced, had a vibrant green garden., with a few garden-gnomes in various shapes. One of them looked like someone who was an old harbinger of news, albeit withered by age and the ways of nature. There seemed to be a lack of flowers on the small mound at one of the edges of the fence. He could hear muffled sounds from inside the house. He walked in the direction of the fences, which turned and lead him to the entrance of the house. The roof was a foggy gray color, with a blue door accented by a number of stars which formed a frame around it. The walls were a mix of the two colors. There was a small window to his right, which was curtained. He could not see inside the house.

He first considered ringing the bell, but then he asked himself which was more appropriate. There was a button on the top left border of the door, and a knocker at the center of the door's design. "Stick to old faithful first, then try other options" he advised himself.

28

He made a fist, with the middle and third finger slightly outstretched from the rest of the fingers. He then knocked on the door. He could hear the sound of something happening inside the house. It eventually led to the distinct tapping which footsteps make on a wooden paneled floor. The door opened, and a small little head poked out from inside the house. He smiled at the boy, cleared his throat, and said to him "Hello there, young man. Hope you would spare me a moment of your time?" The child looked at him straight in the eyes and, after pondering on it for a brief moment, he opened the door and let him in.

It was a modest inner space, with the entrance of the house marked by a shelf with a vase - empty - and the doors opened for the drawing room, the lounge and the kitchen. The child went in the direction of the lounge, where he sat on a sofa and looked in the direction of the garden. The child was asked his name. "Bardia" the child answered. "So, Bardia, what are you busy with" he asked. Bardia pointed at the garden. He nodded at Bardia's answer, and quietly looked at the garden with Bardia.

He thought about something whilst Bardia did the same. He noted that the sound of music and chants again restarted, which he felt was nearby. He looked at the boy again, and cleared his throat once more. He asked: "So, Bardia, well... The Birtash is going to pass by your house soon. Would you like to come with us to..." Bardia shook his head with his eyes closed. He nodded ,and took out a piece of paper from his notepad. "Maybe you would feel comfortable writing why you don't want to go." He said, handing the paper and a pencil to Bardia. Bardia answered on it and returned it to him. He looked at the answer.

29

"I don't like seeing dragonflies. Or insects
What if I get lost? If somebody takes me
What if I lose my parents.
They like it, but I don't. I don't want to go!"

PLEASE... Don't make me go. Mom said I can stay in the house as long as I have supervision.

Please don't make me go...

30

The child keeping his gaze on the garden, was being considered in the context of the note. "Well, is there any place you would like to go?" He asked Bardia. Bardia thought and simply shruged his shoulders. He looked at Bardia and got up. "I'll be going now. If you need anything let me know." He told Bardia, and offered his hand. Bardia got up, and walked with him to the door.

Bardia stopped midway, and held his stomach. When he came close to Bardia, he heard the sound of a missing ingredient. So he took Bardia to the kitchen, took out something from the fridge, put it in a bowl, and he offered it to Bardia. Bardia was suspicious at first, and looked at him with a look that was part apprehension and part confusion. He looked at Bardia, and responded in a calm, but mildly involved voice, with "I had assumed you were hungry. I also assumed that you would like to eat a very sweet food. So I put the sweetest thing in the fridge on to the table". Bardia nodded at the answer - "There seemed to be a lot of nodding up till now, how curious" he thought, looking at Bardia - and with some courage, took a bit from the food. After some time, Bardia took another bite. He stopped counting how many bites Bardia took, after he had noticed the bowl had been emptied.

He thought of something and asked Bardia, "Would you like to have more of it?" Bardia looked at the bowl, and after giving it some thought, Bardia nodded. He looked at Bardia, and said "Once your parents arrive, we can ask them if you could go out with them and have some. Can't leave the house empty, you know what I mean". Bardia just started at him, blank and clearly confused.

31

He looked at Bardia and, bending one knee and looking at him with earnest sincerity, said "I'll ask your parents if they could bring something sweet on their way home." Bardia looked at him, understanding what he meant to say. Bardia took one of the utensils and pointed at the bowl. He refilled Bardia's bowl, and handed it back. Whilst Bardia enjoyed the feast, he walked out of the dining room cum kitchen, took out his notepad and read through his notes. It was clear about some of the details, and how to work on them. He put his notepad back, and looked at the drawer at the entrance of the house.

An envelope was placed on the surface of the drawer. It was addressed to Bardia, and had not yet been

opened. He went to the dining room and asked Bardia, "Don't you want to check your letter." Bardia avoided his gaze, playing around with his food in a distracted haze. He sat o one of the seats, near enough to Bardia to be visible - fully - whilst not being so imposing. "If it is okay with you, would you like me to share what is in the letter.?" He asked Bardia. Bardia nodded to himself for a minute, and then showed his agreement. He opened the letter and read it.

A quiet held in the room. Bardia did not ask questions, nor did he show any nervousness either. He looked at the letter, and occasionally gazed in Bardia's general direction. He closed the letter and put it back into the envelope. "It was instructions from your parents. They want to meet up with us at some place. The address was provided, so I was clearing up where it was. We would leave in some time. I'll wait for you to get ready." He told Bardia, and sat down on the sofa waiting for an affirmation.

32

He noticed that the Birtash festivities grew softer, yet still being audible. It felt as if the celebration was near to its ending. He whistled with the music of the Birtash, bobbing his head too and fro. After some time - "time is relative to what I am doing" he thought aloud - Bardia arrived... Looking familiar, or reminding him of a memory which was familiar enough yet did not seem to be so.

He, with Bardia, left the house, locked it, and then first took a left from the house. They passed by two streets and took a right from the third one. Continuing straight, they reached a Y section where one road pointed towards the school and one pointed towards the library. Bardia tugged his shirt, and pointed backwards. He took out the letter, and showing it to Bardia, said "That is what I have been told. It won't take long. All you need to do is be there, and you will then head home with your parents. I studied in the same place, so I know a few secrets and tales of the place" he informed Bardia, with a tinge of positivity. Bardia softened his grip. He looked at Bardia and offered his hand, saying "We can walk together if you want. I'll share a story with you too". Bardia agreed to the proposal.

33

"The first Qin was said to be as quiet as the sky and as unpredictable as the weather .Just as the fog takes up form whenever it so pleases, the same applied to the Qin. Although he never raised his voice, the first Qin was known to voice his anger through... Rather interesting means. He was passing by our school one day. Some of the boys were doing something, up to mischief and the like - as boys are wont to do, you can imagine. The boys had decided to honk on the school horn, implying that lunch and sport break had commenced. They were successful, but were caught doing so by the first Qin.

"He passed the playground quietly, and once all the boys had gone inside, he walked to the gardener and told him something. I know because I saw him walk to the gardener. I didn't take much notice of it back then. The boys were walking back home when they noticed sand spread all over the entrance of the school. Everyone followed the scrapes and found the sandpit had been completely emptied of sand. In the sandpit, instead, was muddy water and some sort of slime. Qin Laraiez heard about the commotion, and took the situation into consideration.

"The old gentleman who I had seen talk to the gardener, stepped forward, and told everyone about the mischief committed by the three boys. Laraiez, staying calm, took note of the charges and, with mild

annoyance, had everyone leave and return home. The three boys, however, stayed back. Laraiez had not asked them to, no one did - they stayed back voluntarily. I don't remember the looks on their faces, or what they specifically said, but I know they said something related to the sandpit.

"The next day, Laraiez called all of us over to the auditorium, and so, we congregated there. He explained what had happened yesterday, who the complainant was, and the reasons for his mildly annoyed response. However, he commended the three boys for taking responsibility for their actions. And not only cleaning the sandpit, but also making sure that 'Qin Tapkul had been calmed down, informed of the lesson learnt, and their remedy to the mischief'. We cheered the boys when they came on-stage... I found out later about how they had achieved this feat, but I don't remember it now, maybe once we reach the school I'll show you how they did it. Sounds good?"

34

Bardia quietly heard the story, and at the end, he acknowledged his question. Bardia, however, did not have an answer. Bardia shrugged, and did not answer with words. He looked at Bardia and noted the answer. They reached the entrance of the school. Laraiez was waiting at the entrance of the building, tapping his shoes, while looking at Bardia. "You seem to have lost something or been distracted on your way" Laraiez said to Bardia. Bardia kept quiet, showing mild nervousness. "It was traffic, Qin Laraiez. Bardia was ready and out of the house on time. We took a longer route. The fault is mine" was the response to the accusatory rhetorical statement. Laraiez noted the response, and said "Bardia, I expect you in my office after school is over."

Bardia entered the school, where the sound of footsteps overwhelmed the chatter and other assortment of noise that could be heard. He followed Bardia from a distance, making sure that he had reached his requisite classroom. It was the same route which he remembered when coming to school as a child. Once Bardia was inside the classroom, he went downstairs, took the exit to the garden, and sat on one of the benches next to Laraiez. Laraiez was busy at the time, feeding breadcrumbs to ants.

"You don't need to worry about where you take steps. I'm not squeamish about them" clarified Laraiez. He noted the clarification, and sat down.

35

"I never liked insects. They're terrible little things." He commented.
"Indeed, yet a world without insects is barren, devoid of sustained life" retorted Laraiez.
"These places are notably peaceful, and people there are alive - they have more charisma."
"Depends on how you define charisma. Are they charming as a result of their environment, or are they charming, despite being in an environment they know is not sustainable?"
"Or they are charming even though they made their environment sustainable for themselves?"
Laraiez pondered on this point, and asked him "You would honestly prefer living in a desert than in agricultural lands, simply because you hate insects?"

He thought about Laraiez' question, and kept quiet. He looked at the close upstairs. "That is an interesting question."
"Possibly not as interesting as the answer."
He nodded at what Laraiez retorted towards. He shook his head, and looked at Laraiez, saying "Maybe

not... Is there anything about Bardia I should know?"
Laraiez threw some breadcrumbs at the ants, humming to himself. He pushed up his glasses, and nodded to something. Laraiez looked at him, and asked, "What would you say about him?"
"He's not comfortable with the Birtash, and is quiet. But is a good kid. Clearly he is a bit shy, with words I mean."
"Well, yes and no. Yes, he is shy with words and is quiet, but no, if he is a good kid, then he shouldn't cause so much worry as he does." Laraiez clarified, his analysis being firm yet sincere. Laraiez got up from the bench, scraped the breadcrumbs from his hands, and told him "You should be present in the office when I call Bardia over. I'm sure he would appreciate the support."

36

He nodded at Laraiez, and bid him farewell. He looked at the ants, scurrying around the field. Some of them gathered into a big cluster, and with their combined might, they pulled some of the breadcrumbs together with them into their ant-house. He felt a tingling feeling on his back, running up to his neck and down his spine. He got up, more out of an unavoidable, involuntary reflex to be as far away from the insects as possible. He shuddered at his situation, but said to himself, "you are bigger than them, you should not worry about being overwhelmed." He decided to walk over to the office of the Qin.

Bardia arrived at the entrance of the office of the Qin. He was initially worried, but seemed to be at ease once he saw one of his own sitting and waiting. He smiled at Bardia, and asked him "How did your day go?" Bardia shrugged his shoulders, and bobbed his head to and fro. He nodded at Bardia, and offered him a seat. Both Bardia and he, sat next to each other, quietly noting a blank wall opposite to the office of the Qin. He told Bardia "You should know, there used to be a painting on that wall at one point." Bardia looked at the wall, then looked at him. Bardia shook his head in disagreement. He looked at Bardia and nodding, reassuring that there had been a painting on this wall. Bardia disagreed a second time. He got up, walked to the wall, and took note of its details.

"Ah ha! There it is!" He pointed to a hole at one point of the wall. Bardia looked at the hole in question, and gave a look of confusion.

37

Laraiez stepped out of the office and looked at Bardia and him, pointing at a hole in the wall. "That isn't where we hung a painting whilst any Qin was here. I think you have it confused with another building" Laraiez commented, and requested both of them to come inside.

Bardia and he, looked at Laraiez. The Qin had a paper taken out from a report. After Laraiez had completed his reading of some portions from the report, he looked at Bardia. Laraiez asked Bardia, "anything in this report you would like to disagree with?" Bardia shook his head and looked at Laraiez and him. Laraiez looked at him, pointing at Bardia, and said "You have anything which I should know about?" He looked at Laraiez, racked his forehead, and simply raised his shoulders in confusion. "I always thought he would like the library." He commented, looking at Bardia and smiling, patting him on the shoulder. "You're right, in fact, it isn't because of his performance that we wrote what we did. Punbell is happy with his work. That simply does not excuse being... Isolated from the world." Laraiez responded.

38

"He's fine at home."
"What are his pastimes and hobbies at home?" Laraiez inquired.
"He finished his homework, and sits in the garden."
"What about writing? Does he do any writing at home?"
"None apart from what is necessary. He does spend time talking though."
"With whom?" Laraiez asked.
Laraiez nodded at the answer. Laraiez looked at Bardia and answered Bardia's confused, mildly nervous look with "Don't worry about a thing. You just do your best, and smile more often." Bardia left the room with him, and both of them greeted the Laraiez as they reached the door and exited the school.

"Is there any place you would like to go? He asked Bardia, to which he was given a resolute head-shake, and a firm and clear answer: No. He nodded at Bardia's answer, and decided that he will drop Bardia back home. They went down the road, passing by the beach. The fog had been noticeably more tame and calm, to which it almost seemed that time simply did not stop - it kept transition from one point to another. He wondered where they were walking, but did not show it to Bardia. They continued to make their journey - "Considering the time it is taking, it might as well be a journey" he thought to himself - and found themselves at the sign stating "To the Birtash tents."

"You could give it a look if you want. I hear many..." Bardia simply shook his head, walked to the entrance of his house, and turned to face him. He pointed to the door, and stared at him quietly - the look was not of anger, or frustration, but clear decision making, and a firm conviction towards the required outcome. He felt his pockets, took out the keys, unlocked the door, and opened the way. Bardia took off his jacket, handed it over to him, took off his shoes, and walked upstairs to his bedroom. He hung Bardia's jacket, and checked the fridge.

39

He took out some food and placed it on the table, and along-with provided safe cutlery - a spoon - to eat the requisite meal. He took out a paper from the small ornament that had a stockpile of papers in it, and wrote something on it. He placed the paper on the entrance drawer, and put the keys, too, next to it. He noticed Bardia coming downstairs. "Your parents will be heading home soon. I put the keys of the house on the drawer. Paper has something meant for your parents. Food is on the table .Soon as I leave, you go on ahead and get something sweet in you." Bardia nodded at what he said, opened the door, and asked for the keys. He nodded at what Bardia expected, obliged the needful, and left the house.

He thought about what to do next, and decided to head in the direction of the Birtash tents. So, he turned right from the house, and walked straight. He continued straight for a significant duration. He knew he was making progress, since he could hear the sound of carnival music being part of a precession, and it was growing louder and more clear. He hummed alongside, although he still could not see any sign of a procession or a carnival passing through the streets.

He nevertheless, found the sign which lead into the tents themselves. "I think they were intentionally hoping to mislead audiences and also anyone interested in the Birtash" he sarcastically commented. The tents had numerous enclosures, each opening for a specific trade. They were not tents as much as they were marquees, which had things that they would trade for specific reasons and means. It was a

quiet place, with a small number of people focused in specific tents.

40

He decided to take a stroll around the tents. So far, the tents had the usual things he was expecting: one tent was selling lizard tails; one tent had a rotating circle, with various colors, and a big bull eye in the center; one tent was selling books on how to sell books; his personal favorite was a tent in which was written, at the entrance of the door, a specific set of numbers and a time set - they charged for putting someone inside the tent, and leaving them there until someone paid to have them taken out from the tent. "Some would call it ransom, others call it a deposit. We make money" was the slogan of the tent.

At the center of the Birtash tents were numerous stalls, where some people were busy with a lot of people, while the rest of the tents were having heated discussions about what both stall and tents were doing. He went over to one stall, shuddered, and walked over to the next stall. It was selling an assortment of Yivelis, soup, and a grilled beef-box. The sign said "Hot Rind available here. Wait till evening to get a free sample!"

He walked over to the gathered crowd. He could hear someone speaking loudly, yet not very clear from where he stood. He walked forward to the person, and found that the person was a performer. He stood quiet, and listened to the performer's work.

41

"Where is the company you sought?
Among clouds overcast, they are lost
a sign, perhaps, may help you out
for that is what did accost
A steppe of ghosts, they leave the prow
reaping the sadness they have sowed -
a steppe of ghosts...
a steppe of ghosts
like clouds above they are overcast now.

"The silken silver saber tongue
sang its amusing rhapsody;
of emotions incomprehensible, flung
nonchalant, for an audience not seen.
For what is said, naught has been done
the shadow consumes, the tongue, is one
for what is said...
For what is said
look at what it has become!

"A husk which walks the earth; redemption
only through the life it should know - grated without contention"

42

He acknowledged what had been spoken, but had no opinions about it. He couldn't give it much thought. The commotion of something being cooked distracted him. Something specific which he had eaten before, yet could not specifically put into words. So instead, he decided to follow the scent, and where it would lead him. He passed by the tent calling an assortment of sweets. And as he walked, he felt the scent growing in intensity and its general quality. He found it.

"Hello good lad. What will be your pleasure... I see, a good choice. Would you like... No? Very well then. Mostly everyone I've known had it differently... Yes, quite right. There is no true way of eating this dish... You like it from what I gather, should I... Eh, you would like one more? I'm sure he would like it very much. Thank you... Stay blessed..."

He kept thinking to himself as he looked around some more at the Birtash tents. He wondered if there were more attractions available in the vicinity. So he walked around and found himself a telephone booth. All that was found inside - could be found inside, all the same - was the telephone, a page with specific numbers and whom to address, and a directory with numerous colored pages: red for “hospitals and almanac”; yellow for “services”; white for “Lost”; gray for “Numbers”; green for “Arts”; pink for “Nothing related to women unless it’s a funny story or a lady shop”; and black for “All the above, in that order”; brown for "general numbers", silver were "restaurants", cyan for "hotels", and maroon for "every other place on the map which matters".

43

"Curious what a small menial task could do to a town" he thought to himself, as he looked at the map. It was the last page on the directory, marked by the bookmark which had an ornate design and a fine handwriting from someone who had not been very careful about things in general.

He noted some of the locations on his notepad, and the directions on how to reach them. He left the telephone booth, and made his way from the entrance of the Birtash tents towards the street marked "Niner schemes". The lack of any view of the Niner Hotel from any visual point of the map did not phase him. From there, he took a right, then straight till he found a crossroad; walking straight seemed to lead to an avenue that he could recall, but not completely; to the left were an assortment of buildings, in series, which seemed to be on fire yet did not spread, nor did they seem to be phased by this happening; on his right was a road heading downwards. He headed right, and followed the road.

He whistled to himself as he made his way downwards. The smell of bread and fresh fried eggs accompanies by a variety of fruits, some more fragrant than others. There didn't seem to be many people outside. He continued his way, finding the change from two sides covered by buildings, to one side having buildings with an overarching view of the beach.

He continued to walk forward in the direction of a staircase which led downward to the beach. He took the stairs, took off his shoes and felt the sand touch his feet.

44

The sound of the waves pounding the beachhead sounded oddly familiar. He nodded as to the reason for why this was so. He could see some sailors on a boat at the distance, although they were too small to be fully visible from his vantage point. They seemed to be in a situation, yet what that situation specifically entailed was not clear and, it seemed, rather trivial in comparison.

He felt the sand on his hand, slowly making it flow downwards like a river... Flowing down a cliff... Hence making a waterfall. As he made this correction, he heard feet scratching the sand from the distance. He didn't turn back to look at who it was. He remembered a moment from his school days, and during his time spent in the library. And during this stream of consciousness, he recalled some passages of a book he had been following during his free time. It was a novel set in the district of Yivelis, and talked about the origins of the sweet dish.

> *"Most will remember the recipe like a glove, and very few can claim to be unable to cook it, yet the origins of this price - read, a wonderful yet expensive experience for the stomach that is cheap in purchase - feast continue to remain a mystery"*

This was the opening paragraph to the forward of the book "Yivelis", Although in fairness, this was a chapter and not a full fledged book. "It was the only chapter with any substance", he thought to himself.

45

He continued to introspect on the thought, and found himself lost in a forest. He looked around, and noticed a light shining from a distance He decided to walk towards it. It wasn't that the forest lacked any other light-source. It wasn't even the case that the light was of any unique color. He walked onward towards it, noticing that the terrain changed from thick, yet comforting, trees; to a lush, widespread, radiant vista - only the miles upon miles of grassland covering the Earth. Yet the light still shone, completely indifferent to the sight. So he decided to keep walking forwards, that he may be near this source of luminescence.

As he walked forwards, and forwards, something caught his eye. He kept looking, he kept hearing, but then he shrugged. "It was probably nothing significant" he thought to himself, and he saw a granite path, which he took. He was walking alongside a cliff, a reflection of light from the moon shone over the water. That was what he thought was the sighting, yet it did not seem to be the case. The cliff became smooth, and the sound of the waves became calmer. It seemed to be less inclined upwards too... As if the walk was more horizontal. He closed his eyes, and then opened them again. The waves of the water still brushed onto the beachhead.

He noticed that Bardia was sitting on the sand, looking at the water. "A pleasant, calming experience, wouldn't you agree?" He inquired, noticing that Bardia had not responded back. Bardia merely nodded at some thought. He looked at the water, got up, and asked Bardia "Would you like to feel the water on your feet?: to which Bardia looked at the waves, then pointed at his wet feet. He nodded at whatever thought came into his mind. Bardia looked at him, and wondered at the thought he was having. Bardia decided to instead look at the waves and feel the wind pouring from the overcast skies softly caressing his face.

46

"You ever heard about the stork and the way that it had to struggle to get its delivery across?" He asked Bardia, to which he was provided a negative answer. He answered by smiling and then told the tale about the stork.

"There used to be a time that the children of the world had to be delivered to their relevant houses. Quite a complex bureaucracy was involved. Bureaucracy is a heavy word, I would say it was a big bunch of annoyed pigeons who hated traveling further than was absolutely necessary. So they decided to hire new birds to make those deliveries. To this day, these deliveries are done by storks.

"A stork came to the pigeons saying that he saw their advertisement for a delivery bird who would be willing to travel long distances to get the package to its location. The pigeons looked at this fine gentle-bird, and wondered what he actually had in mind when he applied for the post. So they asked it a few questions. He knew his way around the world. He certainly knew his geography, trigonometry, and airship physics. He had a witty way with words, and loved pedantries. But most importantly, he was determined to get the job, and was willing to prove his worth for it. The pigeons were, and still are, a very devious and cowardly bunch of creatures. So they decided to give the stork a shot. They hired him on a temporary assignment.

"This stork had a special uniform tailor-made just for him. Remember, the organization was run by pigeons, who were short in height, tended to be happy sticking to a single point, were unbelievably lazy, and did not have large wings. This stork was a giant in comparison, having twice the wing span in comparison, twice the energy of a pigeon yet not as much as a seagull, and in the case of this stork in particular he had a long neck - unless you had met other storks, in which case it was nothing particularly out of the ordinary. He loved his assignment - it was as if he was destined to be a delivery stork his whole life.

"Some time later, maybe a month or two, the stork received a special order. Before he could proceed with it, the pigeons, and their boss in particular, asked him to report to the meeting room. His first sentence upon being seated, facing the director of operations - an eagle - and the remainder of the key officials, was to comment 'This is probably the conference room'. Only the Director found this comment funny, whereas everyone else thought it was mildly annoying. The assignment was explained to him.

"He had to travel across the sea to deliver a special package. He was initially told that the package was management controlled information, but the director informed him of its sensitivity through subtle cues. The stork understood not just what the package was, but also how important this assignment was for this company. So he packed his things, he went into his room, and signed off everything, picked up the package, and flew off.

"The stork braved through the winds and the fog, he stood his ground and he didn't give up. You see, contrary to what the pigeons had thought, this stork had actually traveled through similar weather just to get the assignment. To him, it wasn't a matter of life or death, or even survival. It was purely a test of strength. And he knew that he would succeed. He used all his experience and skills to not only keep the package safe, but also keep his flight safe from harm's way.

"There was silence in the office, meanwhile. The stork had not provided any response yet. The pigeons

were concerned, but the eagle was confident that all will turn out fine. If anyone among the pigeons had doubts about their boss' judgment, it was driven away the moment they heard him singing to himself. It was one of his favorite songs, something they knew he would sing when he was sure of his decision. After all, he had never been wrong before. The rain grayed the skyline, and the fog did not help matters either. Still, they decided to wait. One of two outcomes was inevitable in this situation - either the stork would reach his destination; or they will receive news that their package did not reach its destination. Still, there was no point in being doubtful, so they hoped for the best.

"After what seemed like a whole day, or rather, as if a day and a night had passed, they received a phone call. There was an overwhelming silence - the moment of truth was here. The director was put on the line, He gave his designation, waiting for a response. And the response came: 'we got another customer, boss. They wanted to thank you personally.'

"The staff gathered at the entrance of their office, to greet him on his successful excursion. They noticed that it had been very rainy the other night, and that the fog had been more prominent that day than they had been prior. But they kept quiet, hoping that the stork will be able to make it safely.

"There was a sharp lightning striking the periphery; the noise from the various things falling down only added to the suspense. And then, there was heard the sound of footsteps. Or rather, the sound of clapping hitting the floor as something made its way towards the office. Its form was clearly drenched in water, its arm and hands seemed as if a deadly weight was pulling it down. Hence why there seemed to be a huddled burden upon the creature. It drew near, without fear... And when it finally came to the light, the eagle smiled. A long arm passed through the rain, and under the small roof of the office entrance, it handed the eagle a letter with the return address of the same place from whence the stork had arrived.

"If you ever wondered why the babies of this world are brought to their respected houses by storks, you have to thank this story for it. Later onwards they gave a name to the stork. Or rather, they found out what his actual name was - it was Rivek Thalroppe, or Dave for short."

50

Bardia was in a confused state after the conclusion of the story. He looked at Bardia and after waiting some time, informed Bardia "You can ask me questions regarding Rivek if you want. Seems to me like you don't agree with most of what has been shared."

Bardia, realizing that he could stay quiet no longer, asked him: "Rivek traveled all the way back to hand over a personal letter? Even though he had informed the eagle that the people wanted to thank the director and the team themselves?" He nodded at Bardia, and responses "Yes, that is exactly what he did and exactly what the director was given." Bardia looked at the waves in wonder. He quietly looked at the waves and the water with Bardia, busy with his own thoughts and perspectives. Bardia broke the quiet and asked another question: "Did Rivek have big wings?" He looked at Bardia, puzzled, and answered "Yes, Rivek had big wings. Why do you ask?" Bardia then responded "I don't think it makes sense for a stork to have large wings, when the director is an eagle. Eagles are huge...!" Bardia stretched out his hands to the furthest extent that he could manage, in order to convey the weight of his point.

He laughed at Bardia's point. It was more of a chuckle rather than a laugh. He looked at Bardia and

asked him "Have you ever seen a stork before?" To which Bardia just gave a blank stare. He looked at Bardia and wondered if he was being genuine, or was avoiding the answer to the question. Bardia responded. "I have, yes."

51

He looked at Bardia and raised an eyebrow. More an attempt at raising an eyebrow than fully raising an eyebrow. He wondered and asked Bardia "If I asked you to describe a stork for me, would you be able to do so?" To which Bardia thought about it and then with a nod, stood up and used gestures to describe something.

He occasionally interrupted Bardia to take more clarity about the description, but mostly he kept quiet and listened to what Bardia had to say. It was less said and more of actions being performed to emphasize the dimensions, look and the sheer presence of what constituted, in Bardia's mind, a stork. He nodded at the conclusion of Bardia's description of a stork, and did not ask further questions. They both wondered off in their minds, to which Bardia was asked: "Shouldn't you be heading home by now? It is getting quite late." Bardia wondered at this point and pointed to the sky. He saw plenty of fog, yet it did not seem to indicate that the day was still ongoing. He got up and walked over to the stairs, with Bardia in arm's reach. They made their way towards the road, from where they traveled for some time and finally reached the house in the middle of the street.

Once he had dropped Bardia back to the house, he made his way to the road. Instead of heading in the direction of the Birtash, he decided to head back towards the shops. So he walked through a series of thoroughfares and opened the door to Elias' shop.

52

"Do you happen to have any models of birds by any chance?" He asked Elias. Elias thought about the question, pondering on the contents of his shop. "I'll have to check, but I never had bought a stork, or bought any bird models for my shop ever." Elias duly replied. He nodded at what Elias said, looked at the dolls and then asked Elias "do you happen to have any dolls?" Elias gave affirmation and showed him the variety of dolls at his various shelves.

He looked at the dolls, and asked questions on occasions. Most of the time he kept quiet. He let Elias speak on the subject matter. He took one of the dolls from its shelf, and looked at what it was made of, what it was wearing, its overall quality, and generally its presence. Elias asked him "gift for a friend?" He looked at Elias and then at the doll he had just picked up. He shook his head and responded "just a deposit". Elias was drinking his tea at the response. There was some discussion to which an exchange was duly made. He walked out of the shop, noting that the flower-shop did not have any free flowers to give for that day.

53

He walked from the shop to the main street, where another shop caught his eye. He entered it, and found that there were plenty of paintings on the shelves, albeit reprints in various sizes. He asked around for a stork reprint, which was duly provided.

With the stork reprint in hand, he made his way towards the road heading towards the crossroad. He headed upwards, and walked past the Niner Hotel. He noticed a couple walking around the vicinity of the hotel premise, but were less fascinated by what the hotel had to offer and were searching for something. The woman asked, or implied that she was asking, a series of questions to the man - questions which were not audible. He turned his gaze away from the couple and continued walking forward.

He noted another avenue as he made his way at the end of the road - "an avenue turning towards another avenue, how original" he thought to himself - and took note of the general affluence and well-maintained *class* of the place he was walking towards. He also noted that some of the roads on the avenue were owned by fairly decent, yet mostly rich, individuals. The thought running in his mind at that point, as he made his way to the bank, was "did I give Bardia the ice-cream box I bought from the Birtash?"

He asked at the reception if they knew where the manager was going to be sitting. The lady responded by informing him of where the manager was sitting, where he would be busy in case he was not sitting in his office, and what time he will be busy with lunch. After sharing all these findings and these facts, she politely guided him towards a seat. He sat down and waited. He took out his notepad and reviewed some notes he had made in the duration he waited. The manager arrived and shook his hand.

54

He took out his notebook and shared a name, inquiring if any information was available on him. The manager pondered, and asked him to wait. He sat down in the main hall. This acted as a lounge from where everyone concerned would be called and made to act their part. He noticed that the roof had a lavish painting - it was not isolated, rather it seemed to be spread out to the whole hall, as each portion was in continuation of the key point. He took note of it and decided to walk in the hallway, to finish the painting.

There was a stork clearly visible among the numerous birds and it carried a sack on its beak - "Dave I gather" he commented. The stork was passing through numerous hurdles, which had been presented beat for beat in the painting. What caught his eye was a portion of the painting where the eagle handed a memento to Dave, in the presence of numerous dignitaries, after which a snapshot of Dave looking at his boss walking to the light, was followed up with Dave being the leader of the company. From what was portrayed, it seemed that he had been quite successful. A thought came to his mind, and with it he looked at the reprint he had bought. It was fascinating that there was no mention of it in the roof mural.

He was still in the lounge, waiting. He decided to open a newspaper, reading through the section marked "The secret suspicious section". It kept him busy for some time, giving him a few tid-bits which seemed new yet somewhat dubious by reference. He put the newspaper down, and took out his notepad. "I'll get Bardia his ice cream, soon as I am done here" he thought to himself, and put the notepad back.

55

He looked around the hall, as the manager requested him to wait. It was related to inviting the concerned individual whom had been intimated about the case. Counting the time spent, a fine gentleman arrived and introduced himself.

"Hello, my name is Rinaar. How may I be of assistance?"
"I had a deposit in the bank some time back. It was under the following details."

The details were perused by Rinaar. There were a few questions asked here and there, but mostly it was an easily followed set of inquiries. Rinaar took leave for some time to confirm these details, and left him at the reception area of the back.

"How can Mr. Bez enter such a secure building?" He inquired as he saw a set of open doors, acting as less a barrier and more a form of courtesy for the general public. Having said that, he wondered why he was the only person inside the building: most of the tellers seemed to be preoccupied with matters that were important - assumably - but did not concern with the public directly. He took the newspaper and read through it again. He had noted something in his notepad when Rinaar returned.

"Yes, sir. All information checked out. I could have someone bring the files and deposits here to you directly -"
"I would prefer looking at the contents at source, Rinaar. If it is all right with the bank."
"Of course, sir. Follow me please."

Rinaar led him through an assortment of halls and chambers, until they reached an elevator. Rinaar called the elevator which was somewhere on the twentieth floor. Rinaar noticed him whistling a tune to a song. Rinaar kept his eyes on the elevator, softly tapping his shoes to the beat of the tune. The transition from a whistled tune to the actual music from the song that played in the elevator did not phase either Rinaar, him, or the people exiting the elevator.

56

Rinaar pushed a button on the elevator, and they found themselves after some time in the basement, where a sign on the wall marked out the direction of the store. Rinaar led him towards it. He noticed while following Rinaar that it was a fairly spacious hallway. The paintings of lava, volcanoes and obsidian did not phase him. "And yet, even now, people think that lava is a useless phenomenon" he said aloud, to which Rinaar replied "It was a subtler time, and meant for a more jurisprudent era. When I was a child, we did not take such matters so lightly - all tasks at hand were resolved by order of immediacy rather than ranked by ease. Like lava, the problem could be contained immediately, or allowed to grow until it led to complete failure and catastrophe." He nodded to Rinaar's point and responded "Possibly. I always thought it had to do with how the dead can count us at any time." Rinaar laughed at the observation, and requested to wait in a room marked "Observations and Reading Area". After ten minutes, Rinaar beckoned him to enter.

Rinaar came in the room bearing a file and a box. He looked at the file whilst Rinaar emptied the box. Rinaar informed him about the documents. Had him sign specific pages on the official use of the room, and pointed a clock and the button underneath it. He was left alone to go through the documents.

57

Taking into account the time, he first looked at the number of documents and skimmed through the contents of the thickest folders. Some of the contents seemed to hold more weight, in terms of date

written and their owner.

He picked up one of the documents. He looked at it first, instead of going from the top or the bottom. All the documents were serialized, which was a good point. The patterns in the documents was also understandable, although it required some time and deductive reasoning to fully grasp. Some of the documents had an assortment of signatures on them. Some of the documents had photos and maps attached to them. To him, it was all according to a pattern... There was meaning behind everything.

He took his notepad and compared what his findings were to what had been actually reported, noted or otherwise put on paper. He smiled at some of the pictures, taking notes of them. One picture to particular had made him chuckle softly as he made a few points about it. "Bardia would like the place. I'll ask his parents about it" he thought to himself as he put the photographs on the table in a box marked "Photographs required". He remembered a few points which he had made whilst at the Birtash tents, and searched in the files for any reference to them. There were none, either directly or indirectly. Some of the documents were letters which seemed to have neither been read, nor had been answered.

58

One of the letters was from Punbell, something which neither took him by surprise, nor did it seem to be something he had prior knowledge about. He decided that , as the sole proprietor and legal owner of the deposit box, he will make a copy of the letter and read it - it might as well be over and done with. He opened the letter and perused its contents.

"I heard the rustling of the last autumn leaves, calmly guiding blackbirds to hail and proceed with the procession. For every footstep came tears from the sky; for every prayer was the ash and dust returned to its rightful owner. Yet on whose behalf it was done, was nowhere to be seen.

"It is only sorrow which is described, my son. Yet what of anxiety? What of fear, if the world you know so acutely, so profoundly, that you could breathe every moment without a second thought... If such a world ceases to be, then what will the world be like? What of hope, my son - the challenge of rising up to the occasion could either be a traumatizing one, or an invigorating one. I see all of these in you. I see, in your quiet demeanor, in your calm consideration of where you are and where you will yourself be... I see, and I believe it to be true, a human being truly realized.

"Heed my advice, do not weep as the blackbirds fly away; 'do not let the procession of the Birtash be spoilt by despair; for he made his choice to go gently into that good night.' I fondly remember that you loved that quote. I believe that it was from "Sermons of the Mirtash", a history book with gorgeous illustrations which you would look at for hours on end. You simply never got enough of it. And when you went to the Birtash and saw all the processions, you were all those emotions: overwhelmed with joy, grief, ecstasy, sorrow, anxiety, hope, anger, excitement... You were alive, and it made me happy to see you grow.

"My son, I love you. And if circumstances had been different I would have tried my hardest to be there for you in your time of need. But alas my son, I must apologize. The blackbirds call out my name... I must walk into the good night, and acknowledge the tears. It is time... I hope, I pray,that when we meet again, it will be in happier circumstances."

59

He finished reading the letter, and looked at the reference sheet associated with it. He made some notes, and put the letter and its relevant documents back into their folder. He took out another set of files and read them. There were details which he took note of, but did not give much attention. "Mr. Bez had too much free time. It was inevitable that he had to go" he deduced, introspecting the picture. He had noticed a flyer was amongst the files; he looked at it, and took note of the fine writing that had been provided on one side of the document. "I think it is time that I visit the flower-shop. It would make her happy" he noted, putting the flyer in his pocket. He filed some documents highlighting this action.

A few more documents were perused as he made his points known... To his notepad. One highlight which had caught his attention was a letter from Punbell. It was brief, barely a letter in content. It felt like a memo to him, although that was wrestling with pedantries. What had made it catch his attention was the following paragraph"

> *"I consider myself a lonely man. My solace is found only in books. My comfort in the library is matched by my apprehension of people. Nevertheless, I consider myself still possessing a glimmer of humanity. When the blackbirds sang at the break of dawn. I chose to offer you a place amongst my friends, of my own volition. A choice for me, but an invitation extended, and open, to you. Whenever you seek to consider it and inevitably accept it, you know where to find me."*

60

He looked at the invitation. The envelope had not been opened. It still gave a scent of fresh postal stamps and vanilla envelope glue. After turning it too and fro, observing it and noting a few details, without opening the envelope, he decided to put it in the inner lining of his jacket. He filled in the necessary documents that came alongside.

He looked further at the documents that were remaining. They were important but at that particular moment they were not especially necessary.

> *"If a man must pick his past, they pick the moments which led to growth.*
> *Even if those moments were enough to leave scars, they fuel growth."*

He had read that somewhere, and decided to note it for reference. He put the remainder of the documents back into the box, making sure that all relevant signatures and confirmations had been made. He got up from his seat and walked towards the intercom. He pressed the button. A series of voices and some clangs later, he heard the door open. Rinaar stepped into the room.

"Were you able to fully peruse your documents?"
"Yes. I mentioned which documents have been taken into account, and which have been instructed for bank purposes."
"It seems quiet a lot of documents to entrust to a bank."
"A simple interest of memories carries a significant weight. With time, the profit outweighs the burden."

Rinaar nodded at what was less a maxim and more a tome of experience summarized into words. "Very good, sir. I will take care of the needful. Follow me please." They made their way to the lobby, where Rinaar bid him farewell, and left him to do his bidding.

61

He looked around at the avenue, thinking about something. It consumed his thoughts for a brief duration. He decided to walk, and he took pace. The sound of trees - leave rustling alongside scurrying about too and fro, seemed like an appreciative welcome compared to the silent, calming, quiet contemplation which was the case with the bank. But he did not give it much thought. "It is the rustling of leaves. It is other sounds which nature makes" he commented on the matter in his mind. His response was whistling a song that came to his mind after much silence.

He continued to walk, noting that the fog had become thicker as he kept walking forward. The sound of footsteps did leave him disconcerted and slightly perturbed. It was not as if the place was unknown - he had walked around the locality on a sufficient number of occasions to be anything but scared. It wasn't even that he had concerns about the fear of something menacing which would bring any dread... The fog was disconcerting, he felt that, but it was not imposing discomfort. What he made out of it was an unknown dread, and that is why he decided to proceed with caution, yet not lend it much thought. His actions proved to be effective - the fog became less intimidating and was much more indifferent. He wondered why he was at the beach, but shrugged it aside. He took to the beaten path until he reached the stairs leading up to Punbell. He took out the envelope from Punbell and saw it a second time, carefully.

He decided to head to Bardia and share his findings. "Punbell would appreciate the gesture anyway" he thought as he took the stairs from the beach to the library heading in the direction of the Birtash tents. He intended to visit the school later.

62

He wondered if the couple was doing well as he had not seen them for quite some time now. This thought came whilst walking down the slope and heading back to town from the library. It also filled him with a tinge of sadness wondering of Bardia's parents had returned to the house. It was a relatively quiet descent, but it proved to be most effective... To walk to Bardia's house rather than take any transport. "A confusing, intricate, Byzantine web of so much happening, so much being coordinated, so many gong from point A to B... An overwhelming arrangement" was his response whenever the topic of busses came up.

He took the turning to the Birtash tents and stepped towards the door. He knocked on it and stepped back to let the owner open it. It was initially quiet and there was no sound to be heard from quite a distance. He rang the bell again, this time slightly agitated. He waited some more and, when he did not get any response, took out a chain of keys and used one to open the door. "Bardia, is everything okay?" He asked as he entered the house. There was no answer for some time. He decided to walk up the stairs to see if he was doing okay. He noticed that one bedroom door was slightly open. He peaked through the door to find Bardia asleep. He nodded and, with care and due consideration, closed the door without making noise.

He noticed the bedroom adjacent to Bardia, in the sense that the entrance had a clear view of Bardia's bedroom door. Going inside showed that it was a well maintained bedroom, but not seemingly utilized in quite some time. Some objects seemed to have been left in place exactly as they would have been found, but all the same it was pleasant. He decided to walk down to the lounge, sit on the sofa, and look out from the window.

63

He had something in mind. He noticed that the number of birds were frantic, even arguing with the squirrels over matters which were significant to the birds and the squirrels, but of the trivial concerns to outsiders. It did leave an impression, nevertheless. The thought of surviving by one's wits even when circumstances felt unfavorable, was ambitious albeit inevitable. He thought so, whilst watching the squirrels make their stockpile for the change of seasons.

> *"A change of seasons is always welcome... To remember how fragile time is; to remind us of how, like crimson sunlight, to imagine what we might find is boundless joy, yet also endless melancholy."*

That was a quote which resonated with him."Who had actually said those lines was less relevant than why. I should look up the book where it was said" he thought to himself as he got up from the couch and looked at the library.

There was a closet a bit further away from the couch, but it was nevertheless a fascinating closet. Some of the books in this closet - and it was a closet, not a library - were from a bygone era. To him they were a bygone era; some mentioned great kings who stood and watched their triumphs fade before their very eyes; some mentioned numerous causes which were made possible by the deeds of both men and women... Something the wicked would attempt to attain by conquest but fail, other things the crooked would attempt by treachery but fail.

The rest of the books were on birds. They were not specifically on the study of birds, rather the cultural context associated with birds - how birds influenced the way society works.

64

The story about the stork came from this book. He read through it again, smiling as he recalled how the stork succeeded in his endeavors. He wondered if there were any books about the stork, recounting his adventures after this particular encounter. So he read through the chapter a bit further. There wasn't anything related to what happened to the stork afterwards, but there was an interesting side-story about the stork which could help shed light on implications about the stork:

65

> *"Nearly thirty years have past since Rivek Thalroppe had made his flight. Dave had grown older, which goes without saying; One of Dave's eyes was dying out on him, so Dave was partially blind; Dave could fly but only for short durations since his body was not able to withstand hard weather; and one of Dave's legs had to be amputated, because surgery was not able to bind*

the bones together. Even with all these factors, Dave kept strong. Dave smiled, provided lectures, and gave practical guidance and tips to new recruits... When they came. For nearly thirty years since Dave's flight, the number of recruits had actually decreased. There weren't that many deliveries. Their services were utilized a quarter of the time annually, rather than every quarter of the month per month. Even so, cancellations were much more common, and accounted for a significant bunch of the income. It simply was not feasible.

"Thalroppe looked at the pictures in his office. He wondered if there was any way he could do one more order. Dave had been discussing it with the board. Whilst Dave's suggestion had been respected and had helped keep the company afloat, both knew that there had been concerns to be considered.

"Dave had shown fervent dedication to this cause; if anything, he would use the legend built from his legacy as a platform to train new recruits, spread the network further, make sure that a feedback loop was in place... He used his own fame to expand an institution, because he believed in the cause. Eagle saw all this effort, and also took note that Dave did everything by the books. Here began the first of many interactions between Dave and Eagle. Now, nearly thirty years later, a letter in hand and with a different tenor, Dave requested the board to let him finish his service by completing one final delivery.

"The board reviewed the details. The client had been the first to test Dave's mettle. Since then, a lot had happened which was important (subjectively speaking). He requested Dave to take the order, because he knew only Dave could be entrusted with it. The board read through the directions but were wondering if Dave could pinpoint the actual location on the map. Dave did as he was asked, and after pointing the location, the board understood why Dave wanted it to be his final delivery. They told Dave: 'He gave you two weeks; we'll let you know well in advance'

"Four days later, an official letter published on a red page, and signed by all present in the board in golden ink, gave Dave the answer: 'He is allowed to make the delivery. May the winds be in his favor, and by his side' to which Dave, nodding prepared for this final journey."

66

He turned the page and noticed that the rest of the portions of the story were missing. The concerned portions had been ripped out, with force. It was enough reason for him to put the book back into the closet. "I wonder why the pages had been removed. Maybe Bardia will know about it" he suggested to himself, while completing the action, making sure that it was tucked in properly. He went upstairs and checked if Bardia had woken up.

"You up yet?" He asked Bardia. Bardia nodded.

"Would you like me to make a snack for you, little one?" To which Bardia gave a positive answer through gestures."Well, you will need to come downstairs to the dining room." He said, in a relatively light-hearted but persuasive manner. Whilst heading to the dining-room, he looked around and, after scrutinizing the contents of the kitchen, managed to prepare a meal.

Bardia arrived and sat on the chair of the dining table, as instructed. Bardia yawned, pondering upon the vast and numerous thoughts in the back of his mind. Bardia rubbed his eyes and noticed that the table was still empty, and there was nobody to be found. Shrugging the situation as a minor discomfort, Bardia got up and took out a bottle of milk from the fridge. There was a small amount left, So Bardia chugged it all down, tossing the bottle into the waste-bin and headed back to the dining table.

67

After what seemed like an eternity, but really was just ten minutes, he came and said "In case you are still hungry, or want to wash the milk down", offering the meal of eggs, beef, rice, and potatoes.

Bardia looked at the meal then at him, and returned the gaze back to the meal, wondering at what had been provided. After a few minutes, Bardia asked "How do you eat this?" In a tone that was less angry, or curious, or sarcastic, more a state of wondrous awe. He returned with a fork and knife, and taught Bardia what the meal was, how it was cooked, and what were the ingredients in addition to the core ingredients. Bardia took a bite, then another one, and continued doing so until he had finished all of it.

"How do you feel?" He asked Bardia whilst picking up the dishes. "Happy! As happy as can be. That was amazing! Thank you!" Said Bardia and hugged him. He was taken aback by the action, and only responded back with a light tap on Bardia's shoulders.

As Bardia went upstairs, he asked Bardia a few questions. The fog had started to slowly and steadily become opaque. The scent of something also marked its presence in the house. Both Bardia and he decided to get ready, and head to the school. Whilst waiting for Bardia, he decided to turn on the radio. He noticed it lying in a corner, on one of the ledges adjacent to the window: he was wondering if it worked. The initial crackling followed by the slow clearing voice was evidence, sufficient to prove the correct answer.

"Chance of light rain, followed by a chill, and snow forecasted in the morning... Noted" he said, and then turned it off. Both Bardia and he left the house, with Bardia locking the door. Bardia walked hand in hand with him to the open. He made sure that they both of them had umbrellas, and had kept them up.

68

A thought came to his mind as he made his way to the school. He looked at the numerous empty spaces surrounding him, only to find that he was not able to see anything. He held Bardia's hand, and pushed forward. "It is only a light drizzle; should pass by some time soon" he thought to himself. Both Bardia and he hummed a song as they left from the street, turned, and walked until they reached "Samson Square" - "how can a circle be a square?" To which he told Bardia, pointing at the square, "Samson". They crossed the road, and then turned towards "the tenth turn". It was a small stroll, and then they found their way to the road leading to the school.

"Could we stop at the beach on the way back?" Bardia asked. "Provided the weather clears, then yes, we will." "Why are we going to the school? I went there yesterday." Bardia commented. "It was a matter of time. You will know when you get there" he responded, patting Bardia's head.

The road started to slowly ascend, and it seemed that the weather had also changed for the better. "Better the chills than the drizzles" he thought. He hummed a song: Bardia introspected on the song, and started humming alongside. Midway, Bardia stopped humming, and so did he, after some time, as both turned their gaze towards the road. The weather had made the umbrella a useful instrument to hold on to, especially with the prospects of snow that will pour down. That was what he thought.

69

They reached the crossroads. They headed up, and took the turning towards the school. He looked at Bardia, wondering at the silence and the general distracted gaze. He stopped thinking about it once they reached the school entrance. Bardia went to his classroom, Laraiez greeted Bardia, and gestured him to wait. Laraiez looked at him, and took him to the Qin's office once Bardia entered the classroom.

"It has been a while since you last visited."
"Has it been a while since I caused problems?"
"Well that is true. Punbell had mentioned that you had been quite busy in the library... Were doing quite a good job too."
"It is routine, I suppose. Make hay whilst the sun shines. Or when you have time.:
:Time: the one thing everybody wants, yet nobody has. So, what is it you bid me this time?"
"It... Is much more than a bid... I would say that it is a favor."
"A... Favor?"
"It is a personal matter. And requires a delicate, sensitive eye to resolve. I would have approached anyone else. You were the ideal person to approach."
"I see... So what you are seeking is advice, not a favor."
"If you seek to look at it that way... It is about Punbell."
"... A kind gesture from Punbell. Shame you are not taking it up."
"I suppose... Although considering we are talking about Punbell."
"Very well... If that is how you wish it to be, I will let Punbell know."
"... What about Bardia?" "... Very well, no harm in talking about it."
"Bardia! Please, come in!" Said Laraiez as Bardia entered and sat down.

70

Bardia, Laraiez, and he sat down and talked for some time, then he and Bardia bid Laraiez goodbye as they left the office.

"Punbell invited you to something?" Bardia asked him. He nodded.
"Do you plan on going?" Bardia inquired, to which he looked at Bardia and said "I don't know." Bardia and he headed out from school and left the premise.
"How did school go?"
"It was interesting."
"Oh? Anything I should know about?" He asked Bardia. Bardia spoke and was heard. They continued to talk until they reached the beach, from where Bardia took off his bag. He picked up Bardia's bag and

made sure that it was properly closed in the locker. He headed to the beach.

The sound of the waves calmed any doubts in Bardia's mind, and both Bardia and he simply made the most with the moment. Both Bardia and he had mats placed on the sand, learning from the experience they both had. Whilst the waves made their argument, the fog changed and plotted and schemed... At least that was what the clouds seemed to indicate. There seemed to be a thought in his mind as he heard the waves.

"I remember seeing a couple here in the vicinity. You happened across them by any chance?"
"When? I haven't seen or heard of any such thing."
"When... Is a unique question to ask."
"I mean, when did you last see them? If I know the time, I can respond accordingly." He wondered at Bardia's answer, and stayed quiet for some time. He then responded by "It was quite some time ago, I suppose; they probably have left by now, never mind." Bardia shrugged at the answer and lay back on the mat.

71

He closed his eyes. The sound of the waves was prominent, but calming. It was the only sound that could be heard. That was fine: there was nothing that came to mind as he thought about many things. Some seemed to be more specific than others.

He thought about his time in the library. He could only remember the moments when his parents would drop him, or when they would pick him when he was done with work. He kept on pondering, wondering why he couldn't remember his home, or what happened afterwards to warrant the letters from both Punbell and his father. He still had the invitation from Punbell, something which Laraiez advised on and provided his support. He thought of Elías and wondered when was the last time he met the shopkeeper. All the memories were from either when he was young, or when he came back. "What happened in the middle?" he asked himself. He continued to ask these questions, wondering about Bardia as well. It was more of an afterthought. He continued to ponder upon the matter, and wound up being awoken by Bardia "I think it is getting late, we should go" Bardia requested him.

He got up and folded both mats, after having the sand removed. Both of them got to the entrance of the beach, wore their shoes, and walked to the road. "Do you have a place in mind? " Bardia asked him. To which he nodded, and walked silently. They continued to walk until they reached a crossroad. Instead of taking any turn, he continued to walk straight until he reached a place marked "*The Short Straw*". "It is quite a shortcut" he thought and made his way through the building to the marketplace. He walked over to Elías.

72

Elias was putting some pots and crockery into a box when he entered the shop. "Fancy seeing you again" he said to a plate, which he cleared and then put into the box. Elías picked up the box and took it with him to the back of the store. He went to the counter, and heard Elías running a conversation with someone. It was not very audible, and it seemed of little consequence. Bardia looked through the window and wondered at what was being discussed.

Elias stepped out of his room and towards the counter. “Just got a new shipment of tea and a few other items. Interested?” Elías asked him. He wondered at what these items might be and then turned arnd, looked at the window, and waved Bardia to enter the shop. When Bardia entered, Elías walked towards him and offered his hand.

“Hello there, young man. Pleasant surprise.”
Bardia shook his hand and smiled, although his gaze was clearly distracted by something in the shop. Elias looked in the direction in which Bardia was looking. He picked up a stick which had a hook grafted on to the end. He took out some of the objects from the shelves and after some time, whether Bardia mentioned it or whether he mentioned to Elias what Bardia liked about the object, Elias would turn the object to its rightful place.

“Yes, quite a collection, but still quite a long way to go before I can call it a complete collection”
Elias sighed, and shook his head.
“There is... are... so many places to go, before I can be fully conclusive with what I have. I do wonder though...”

73

Elías went to the checkout counter and made a cup of tea. “Would you like some?” Elias asked Bardia Bardia gave a look of wonder, and he patted Bardia on the shoulder, nodding. He showed two fingers to answer for himself and Bardia. Elias put the water in the kettle, and prepared the cups accordingly. He took the cup from Elias and handed it to tank. Bardia looked at the saucer for a prolonged duration, fascinating by the design and the picture in it.

Elías took note of this observation. “You have never been to the Birtash, have you?” Elias asked Bardia. Bardia looked at him, wondered at the question, and responded with a shaking head. Elias drank his tea in silence, and would occasionally glance at Bardia. There was a shopkeeper curiosity in his eyes as he wondered about the response Bardia had provided. Elias hummed, put the cup down, and went to the back of the room. Elias came back with a plat of Yiveliz. Bardia, clearly ecstatic and excited, but trying to keep his calm composed self, smiled at seeing the Yiveliz. Bardia noticed that Elias was not looking and, thinking it was an opportunity, decided to take a Yiveliz. Elias hid his smile behind his cup.

When Bardia completely finished the Yiveliz, Elias asked Bardia: “Have you ever been to the Birtash?” Bardia looked at Elias and answered the question. Elias sighed and commented: “That was a long time back... really does seem like an age has passed by”. He nodded at Elias’ comment, and looked at Bardia. Bardia was completely clueless about the implication of the comment, but nodded more out of sympathy and to remain a part of the conversation.

74

Whilst he was busy listening to Elias, Bardia checked the doll collection which Elias had started some time ago. There were various ones here and there. One which stood out was the stork. Bardia kept looking at it, but not touching it. He saw Bardia and kept Elías busy whilst Bardia was doing so. Elias kept a conversation to an extent where he wound up looking at Bardia, and with a calm, gentle yet sincere tone, he asked:

"What are you really interested in? You've been looking at that stork quite intently for quite some time. It isn't Dave, if that's enough to answer your question."

Bardia wound up turning to Elías and taken aback, looked at Elías very awkwardly. He looked at Bardia and then at Elías, and with an equally indifferent tone, asked: "is it natural for water to boil for so long?" to which Elías, turning and noticing the water, pointed his pipe at him, nodded his head as if to acknowledge the subtlety of the statement, and removed the kettle. Elías poured the tea in all three cups, and beckoned all three to have the brew. Bardia was reluctant, still even confused. Bardia was looking at the stork and drifting gazes between the doll, the stork, and Elías.

Elías, taking a sip from the tea, remarked: "You have never been to the Birtash." And then turning to him Elías asked "or has he?" whilst tilting his head towards Bardia. He looked at Bardia, and then told Elías "He has a big collection of books on birds. Has a lovely view of them from his house as well."

75

Elías looked at the street, lost in thought. Elías seemed to have something in mind, and after finishing his tea, Elías took out a notebook... and then went to his office from where Elías took out a collections dossier. Elías requested Bardia to take a look, and pointed at a specific page on the dossier. Bardia was fascinated and observed the image for a significant duration. He saw Elías and Bardia in this state and wondered if there was something that was related to any ideas which Bardia had. But he didn't say anything, letting Bardia have the moment.

After some time, Elías asked Bardia "Have you been to the Birtash?" The question was in a very curious, albeit understated tone. Bardia turned and looked at Elías, completely clueless about how to respond back to it. Elías nodded, as if the question had been answered. Elías turned from Bardia to him, and told him "There's a very funny little arrangement set to happen at Samson Square. You've probably been to the Birtash... Why not give it a look?"
He looked at Elías and answered "Never heard about any such arrangements at Samson. We just came from there."
"Why did Samson call a circle, a square?" Bardia interrupted Elías and him. Elías turned to Bardia and responded: "It is a century old joke. The people who remember it are long since dead. Everyone else just roll with it." Bardia nodded, somewhat satisfied at the answer, yet not exactly sure what to make of it. He noted the puzzled look on Bardia's face and asked Elias: "You know anyone who could give any informed stories on Samson? Apart from Punbell?"

76

Elías considered the question, sipping his tea in silence. Elías took the cups and placed them inside his office, humming to himself as he did so. Bardia looked at Elías with a puzzled expression., although it was not out of disregard to the question asked. Elías came back, still pondering on the question, and sat in a chair, facing tank and him. Elias answered in a modicum of finality and asid: "You probably might not know this, but the school was built around the same time the celebration of Samson's Circle had taken place. Why not start from there? See what the Qin has to say?"

He turned from Elías to Bardia, and then asked Bardia: "You want to head to school later when there is a day off?" Bardia thought about it, albeit in a more excited tone than a serious one. And answered with

an excited nod, a smile, and a handshake between Elías and his self. They looked at Elías and appreciated his wares, and both Bardia and he left the shop with Elías smiling behind them, from the counter. He noticed a customer entering Tabitha's shop.. The person was a lady, although it seemed that a gentleman accompanied her as she seemed to enter in a sort of forceful way, rather than in a composed and curious manner – the way customers enter a shop.

Bardia and he looked around the shops, after which point he asked Bardia about a painting. Bardia, excited, raised many questions on the matter: they both looked at the painting, with Bardia being awestruck by it. There seemed to be a lot of awe over the contents of the painting. "It is for the best" he thought, looking at how happy Bardia was. "We alreaedy have the paintings reprint. I''ll show you later" he informed Bardia.

77

"Could we go to the bank first?" asked Bardia, and was promptly given a curt response "No." Bardia looked at him, somewhat miffed at the answer. He bent his knees, and told Bardia while keeping eye contact "The bank is closed. If it makes you feel any better, we could go to meet Punbell. It has been a while, plus he and the school are nearby". Bardia promptly said no by shaking his head with significant energy, although he knew that Bardia was only using enough to prevent injury to himself.

He noted the response and decided to follow the beaten path; it should lead to a place of respite, sooner or later. There were a few, very disturbing thoughts which came to mind as a result of his idea of visiting Punbell first. He brushed them aside as a by-product of lethargy and decided to take some rest on one of the benches. Bardia asked if he was hungry, to which he responded in the negative. Bardia ate from the snacks that he had packed alongside and looked around. It was a quiet view, and yet it did not seem to be all as quiet as it should be.

"It is nature's way" he thought, ass he let the situation soak in. The sound of squirrels, frogs, ducks, pigeons, and occasional badgers was sufficient to keep the imagination of any person flow vibrant. It was a calming scene, and his thoughts wondered off again onto another series of thoughts. He seemed to be in a distant place, yet very familiar faces roamed around. Just as he was about to push deeper into such a thought, he was shook awake from his slumber and asked by Bardia: "you having the last one, or may I?"

78

He looked at Bardia and acknowledged the request. After finishing the last one, they headed to the road. The fog was less prominent in the way.

"It is when we are distracted that the mystères of life take hold, and simply refuse to let go" he found himself considering this quote, which began the preface of the book he was reading. It looked around, expecting Punbell to arrive, what with the noise of footsteps. "Footsteps do not make noise, they make sound. Even if it is a library, the matter is pertinent" he would chid to no one but himself, or so was written in the book, and the grating sound of the wheels of a ladder, left unhinged, slightly marking the transition of one hour to the next. And at the clock's strike, it marked a moment... which seemed to be momentarily mundane and only mattered to those who held such moments with a state of significant regard. He didn't; he had a commitment to take care of.

He went downstairs, and noticed Punbell was preoccupied with an administrative matter. “He had been one of our best patrons, and sufficeth to say, it is sad to watch him lose himself... Oh, is that right? I didn’t know they were unaware... well, some other time then, be sure to come next week.”

79

He took the staircase and went down to the beach, from where he continued straight past the guard post – “how can you guard the endless bounds of water, when it does not guarantee guarding you?” – he walked onward. He found himself facing a parking lot. Heading upward – he took the staircase to get to the parking lot – he walked and was amusing himself with a memory.

“There is something for you” to which an item was handed. He remembered reading this line somewhere in a book. It was the beginning of a very fascinating mystery short story – amongst the few things which seemed to have held his attention, apart from Rivek Thalroppe. Yet, among the numerous times he had read these books, he never knew the author. Quite literally, he did not know the author: he recollected the stories where the perpetrator of the act was always any person lurking where the crime had been committed, always a person faced by circumstances towards the act, and the person who caught the perpetrator was an honest, upright, well groomed officer of the law. And yet he did not know the name of the author.

He remembered when, near the end of a library shift, he had noticed Punbell having a cup of tea. “Something on your mind?” he asked blandly. After taking up and finishing half the tea, Punbell responded in a bored, monstrous voice “The gentleman in question never bothered writing his name. if it was a woman she would have used a pseudonym, or a nom du plume.”

80

“I believe that a person hiding their identity only causes maters to escalate” he thought, as he walked his way to the turning. He walked straight, and as he turned right, he noticed Bardia looking at something, placed behind a window. He walked up behind Bardia, and looked in the window. While most of the displayed items were mediocre at best, or mundane in the general case, he understood why Bardia stopped and continued to stare into the window.

The cover had an aging bird, and a bearded man, marching through some unidentified land; the man was armed with a gun, and the bird seemed to be in an artillery mole. It looked like his final chapter.

Bardia was holding onto the toy, disappointed at the high price. He looked at Bardia and smiled, stating “I believe that someone has a a lovely day today”. They walked into the shop, and towards the counter.

“Good day, and many wonderful salutations! I hope... OH! Oh indeed! It was recently put in stores. You’re quite lucky, because we had just restocked... A man of great taste. In fact, the editor worked with our very own Punbell... So there seems to be an offer in place on the book. If you pay extra, then not only do you get a signed copy, but also a special extra that contains notes and other miscellany... Have a good day! Happy reading!”

81

Bardia appreciated the book in the palms of his hands. “I believe we have to go somewhere, wouldn’t you agree?” he asked Bardia, to which Bardia noted a crowd of pedestrians who had worn the same cap, passing by – they seemed to be interested in the going-ons of the city, as tourists tend to do. Most of them had questions, regarding the Rivek Thalroppe celebrations, and the Birtash, and the streets upon which they were walking. Bardia found himself facing a street lamp, a pedestrian crossing, and a traffic light.

He held Bardia’s hand. Bardia was nervous, scared, doubtful, and even to a certain extent he was not willing to cross that pedestrian crossing. “Better to face the music now, than to forcefully remove noise later.” He spoke aloud. Bardia, taking a deep breath, looked at the traffic light, and when it turned green, crossed the road. Bardia was heading to the hospital, with the book that he had just a few moments back been gifted. He looked at Bardia, and noticed that an emotion marked out the state of mind he was in: dread. “One must always be willing to face one’s mortality. You can’t do anything to alter that. What you can do is make the process easier by retelling the good that happened, and the good that men do” he advised Bardia, who was waiting outside in a lobby, staring at a door.

A nurse came out of the room and beckoned Bardia inside. Bardia walked in and was greeted by the patient: a stately, yet pale, gentleman whose age had left his contenance bereft of joy; yet the moment he saw Bardia, he smiled, and requested the visitor to come near.

82

“Hello... I honestly was not expecting you to come here” said the patient. Bardia smiled, but lacked anything specific to share with the patient. “Bah, don’t be so afraid, my boy. It is just a scratch?” Bardia smirked and with an exaggerated yet low voice he exclaimed “A scratch? Surely a scratch does not warrant being hospitalized! A mere tourniquet should suffice!”

Bardia and the patient laughed at their inside joke. After they collected themselves, the patient took note of the book which Bardia held, and to it Bardia said “I thought we could read it together, like we used to back home.” The patient smiled and agreed to the suggestion, and Bardia sat down near to him, opened the book and read it.

“It seems that Dave has finally found the boy.”
“That actually was hinted in the previous book. He... he... we concern ourselves with how he plans on escaping.”
“Wait a minute. When was he kidnapped?”
“You didn’t know? He was kidnapped during the previous book. The whole portion in which he is writing in first person and those bleak descriptions of life?? They were all while he had been held captive.”
“I don’t remember those portions – “
“–because they were never read aloud. I read the book whenever you had to go to take care of mom. It was one of the two things I could manage.”

83

“You knew about the book and where to find it?”
“I did, father. I didn’t mean to read the portions without your permission. I always thought you were

like Rivek Thalroppe saving the world, and bringing joy to other families."
The patient laughed, and looked at Brdia with endless appreciation. "I had always found the apparent inflection of the book to be... suspiciously unintentional curiosity."
"Your supposition does hold ground now, when considering our general presence in the room."
"Oh yes, the room. I had completely forgotten about it. How are the birds, my dear boy?"
Bardia looked at the ceiling and the rest of the room, finding something that made him uncomfortable, And it manifested in the answer "Chirper. Than this room. I never knew you had only the outside window for company. The lack of a window is quite distressing."
"A minor inconvenience" the patient responded in a dry, and avaricious tone, and winking at Bardia. They looked at each other and laughed, considering the situation he was in. Bardia sat next to his bed, and held his hand. And it occurred to him that he was missing something. He asked the patient "do you have anything by which I could remember you? Anything by which I may carry your legacy?" And the patient informed him to discuss the matter with Rinaar, at the bank. "I am so grateful for this day. Thank you, my son. Alas I must rest now. Perhaps we will continue our meeting tomorrow?"

84

Bardia acknowledged his father's request with a tinge of regret and an abundance of calm composure. He stoked up on his feed, walked to his father, and requested if he may kiss him on the forehead. He was granted this permission, and completed the task with a modicum of grace and humility.

Bardia and he walked out of the hospital. And he took his leave, walking to the main thoroughfare on the corner of Colonial Point, and turned to the avenue following the redwood. He looked around to his amusement at the number of tourists who had busied themselves in the vicinity. "If they are indeed somewhat enthusiastic about this region, they would make a pretty penny for the Hillview Hotel" he thought to himself as he made his way past the avenue. "Something my father once told me about mother, perhaps I could let her know." He thought wondering at the envelope in his pocket. He had taken it out and read it in Tabitha's Flower Shop.

"An excellent choice; young and eternal, forever blessed in the paradise we could only dream of... surely to pay for complimentary flowers is foolish... yes, ndeed, you are quite right; she would be most proud... do visit again whenever you pass by" he heard, to which he looked at Tabatha, smiled, nodded his head, and bid farewell. As he walked ast the avenue, and turned right, and took some twists an turns, he found himself facing those words. He responded with his offering, and a moment of contemplation.

85

"You probably have something to give to her, right?" he asked, and Bardia stepped out from the tree where he had been observing the proceeding. He looked at the tombstone, and the empty plot which had been readied for someone. The garden, laid out with care and concern for her, was abundantly nurturing flowers. Chrysanthemums, tuplis and a star of Birtash were amongst the ones planted. Bardia sighed and placed the singe stalk of the desert rose and then requested if he may share something with her. Taking the silence, as well as some clearing off the fog, to be an affirmative he sat n one of the chairs provided and aed portions from a notepad:

I remember father being constantly worried about your health and countenance. As diligent and as loyal as he had been in life, I had tried to be the same. In that I could show how much I cared for you. I had disavowed

my vows – I promised an abstinence of speech, until your health improved. I realize that I had been miscalculating my actions, inasmuch as children are prone to such approaches. It is never too late to say you matter to me: father and you had your reasons for sheltering me, and to that I can only say that it was for the best;but with each passing day, with each moment, I realize that my silence had rendered me unable to speak with you. To let you know that you were a part of my life. You still are – the birds I count in the morning light, the support from Punbell in matters of a literary concern, the small kindness of Mr. Elias, all remind me of you. And in all, I hope we met often in this place, such that the ghosts of the past are buried."

86

Bardia looked at the letter, moved and slightly tearful. A hand was placed on his shoulder, and told Bardia "Let it go. I'm sure she would understand" he looked at the changing fog, which engulfed the graveyard, and consumed it. The sound of the wind had become strong and with it had a moment of doubt first come. Then it passed. He looked at the rose, and nodded "I hope you find closure, knowing the truth" he thought to himself as he walked to the gate of the cemetery.

He simply decided to walk until a direction would make itself known. "After a ll, everyone seems to be directed somewhere" he quipped, taking interest on the change of dresses. He took the turning from Colonial point through to the Niner Hotel.

He rang the bell a the reception and was responded by a gracious "May I help you? " by Homeiz. "Why yes, she had a message for you. A moment please" and while Homeiz searched, the sound of music would be heard. "A package was delivered to your room. "I'm sure you will know what it means since it is marked" answered Homeiz. He smiled at Homeiz and acknowledged what was said.

In his room, he looked at the package. But did not open it. He read through the letter on the desk, and wondered, smiling at the small gathering near the lake. He changed his clothes and wrote a note. A call was made to which he responded in a positive tone. He closed the phone and opened the door.

Upon the opening if the elevator, the man answered "Bardia, my boy!"

87

Bardia was pulled from the elevator and taken along with another friend to a gathering of people. There was plenty of music, "street musicians probably from the Birtash making a living" commented one of the gentlemen. Bardia noticed the snarky tone in which the comment had been made, and said "They must be good if someone lifted them from the Birtash. If we had done that in the age of the King's, I'm sure somebody would have to grind the axe" Most of the gentlemen laughed at the profundity of this point of fact, and discussed on those topics.

"I'm sure Lady Tabatha must be around. She had an inkling about these pollinating populations" thought Bardia, as he made his way around the crowd. One of the ladies spotted Bardia and responded by holding his hand and exclaiming 'I am so glad you came. Bardia, have you met Lady Tabitha?" to which Bardia responded, "I may have seen some of your work in the Birtash. Beautiful arrangements, honestly" and they shared some polite comments, a quip, and a comment about the lighting. Bardia continued to walk through the crowd ad mingled with most of them.

And near the stroke of midnight, a troupe of performers came who marked the conclusion of Birtash. It was applauded, appreciated, and acclaimed in spirit and form. However, one by one, the crowd started to make its way home. Those who had been residing in the hotel stayed just a while longer until, when all outsiders had left, they too returned to their rooms. "What a party. Homeiz' father would be proud" exclaimed one participant.

"I don't believe that Homeiz had anything to do with these arrangements" thought Bardia, walking between guests towards the delicacies section. He had already made his movement from the entrance of the party which only stood out because of a plaque having the words "one celebration of twenty years – an anniversary dinner" and as you walked forward, with the columns on either side marking the depth of the hall, you noticed a raised platform where Bardia had an empty seat reserved for him, from which he would have a raised view of the guests.

"Homeiz would have come here if given the opportunity" he thought to himself, wondering at the absence of a familiar face. He was facing the delicacies table, where an assortment of condiments, salads, and a stew made from sheep and hens were available for the guests. Most of them relished the stew while seated on one of the many seats and round tables, often with friends but sometimes alone. Elías was on one such seat, busying himself with Yiveliz and a cup of tea. As Bardia walked over to him, Elías smiled and spoke nonchalantly "I seem to be in limbo: this tea did not taste as it does now" he decided to avoid drinking further and looking at the crowd, merely spoke "they are gathering forward to hear an arrangement. I suppose we should as well" and all made their way to the stage.

Except Bardia. Bardia merely walked and bid his leave as he made his way out of the hotel. He made his way to his car, with coffee in his hand.

89

He had already packed everything and placed them inside of the vehicle. The trunk had been assorted. As Bardia sat in the car, he hit the gas after ensuring that the gear was set to reverse. It was on a moment notice that was running on the radio as the car made the curve. It was a cloud day and the car was clearly howling a lot of love. It was in nearly mint condition. Bardia whilstled to the tune of the song running on the radio, as he took the right from the downhill drive to the main thorghfare intending to go somewhere.

"The coast seems to be clear" he thought as he turned through the Birtash avenue onto the part of "Justin's Intersection". On the way, he saw a park. Taking a turn, he went to the parking lot and made his way to the nearest open source. "Nothing better than right in front of the entrance." He exclaimed, smiling, as he made his way to the park itself.

He walked around the place, with the sound of beds, leaves rustling and cheer coming from people marking the presence of people who were coming and going. Most of them seemed to be there with someone as if they were alone, they were making do with movement around the park, with an aimless movement. "Apparently such movement is healthy for the body. I fail to see how" he thought as he tried finding a place to sit down. According to the signs, there was a sitting place a while away from him, and if he took some time to breathe, he might miss it. The approaching hedge seemed to indicate the presence of a bench.

90

He sat down on the bench and realize that there was nothing to look at except a wall. While it seemed tempting to stay there and be left to imagine the history of the wall, and how it had caused someone trauma and had left such an important influence upon the person's who were present there perhaps even shared a historical movement for anyone to be introspective about, he got up and continued walking until he found a bench which faced another portion of the park.

He noticed that there were families that sat down here and there having a picnic on the benches and tables. A few had brought their cooking materials with them, and were enjoying the present company and the splendor of being "one with nature". "If one is already in a park surrounded by natural beauty, then how else should one be considered one with nature except living there?" he wondered as the families enjoyed the afternoon fsun with sandwiches and coffee and tea and juice and outdoor games.

He noticed a couple sitting on one of the benches with an attached table. They seemed familiar except that they were much older. An element of happiness marked them out as they made their way – or rather, not seemed like their son made their way – clear, as they had food. What they talked about did not matter in context as the actions and actual presence of their son – and possibly, the rest of the family as a young child would interrupt them to show something from his book. Who was not smiling often, but showed a significant amount of covers for them.

91

It seemed that the people were gathered around for a performance by someone, or perhaps by a major act, as they were moving to a rightwards direction, with the accompaniment of pronounced, definable breathing in a harmonic rhythmic and musical tone. The old couple and their son seemed to be indifferent to these sounds, although the younger child was much more intrigued by these sounds. Bardia noticed the chiding and the constant push towards going where the sound was coming from, anyone who would preferably give a response at least.

The sound caught Bardia's ear because it was, at least lyrically, very familiar to something he knew. Something he had written perhaps, a very long time ago. Bardia looked through his pockets and found a paper on which the piece was transcribed and spoken all that time back.

I had once walked through the breeze of
An unkempt, forlorn dream; where I
Had stopped to wake up, I know not. The puff
Of a thought disappearing before my eye
Money marked that abrupt transition.
We have seen beyond the clouds, I know
Far more than what we speak in vision
Abolution in that which is beyond, which grows
Like a tree granting eternal life, yet not
To those who seek adventures,
But I have no place from that tree, only to rot
As those who were led only by their futile rapture:
The Doors beyond are a gathering, to us seeking

A purpose to our lives, strength in meaning"

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"Truth be told, it was not a very enlightening piece. Or anything to boast about" commented Bardia, as he wrapped the paper and placed it in his pocket. He noticed that the couple and their son and their family were slowly making their way to where the sounds were being played. Bardia was about to get up when he noticed a child sitting by himself on the bench just a little while ahead from him. The child was sitting by himself and did not seem like there was anything accompanying him. Bardia got up and ws thinking about the child. He stopped, and walked to him.

Bardia smiled, and asked "Good day, young man. How are you? "
"I am quite well, sir"
"Are you waiting for someone? "
"No, just looking at the clouds and the fields."
"I see. Well, if it isn't a problem, may I join you in looking at these fields? They have quite a story to tell."
"I suppose, sir, you may."

Bardia sat next to the child and they looked at the field and the clouds together. The changing moods seemed to be reflected up above and noticing these, Bardia asked the child "Are you familiar with the Man with the Skies?" the child, confused, asked "The Man with the Skies?"
Bardia pondered on this for a moment, and with an approving nod, and a smile showing enlightenment and responded "It is a fascinating story, and might even catch your interest."

A Simple Interest of Memories

Rinaar Lon Daneer had been reading his newspaper quietly as he took note of the time and the entrance. The lobby was, and would always be, the pride and joy of the building; that was what he thought. And maybe he would have been ready to debate on this point. Provided that the building was filled with people. At the time when Rinaar would start work, he was the initial employee in the building. The only sounds to be heard were the hovering of the fan, and the screeching noise of his seat. Rinaar was expecting a guest today. At least according to the schedule he had been provided. "I suppose I should deal with the request of Mr. Bez here and now." Thought Rinaar, as he decisively rolled the newspaper to greet Mr. Bez. It took a while, but Mr. Bez received a warm welcome. Rinaar cleared his eyes using the forefinger and thumb of his right hand; Mr. Bez had misspelled one of his crossword answers. He shrugged it aside as a valiant effort. He looked at the clock and decided to wait – it would be two in nearly fifteen minutes anyway, so why not wait? Rinaar looked at the desk neighboring him. Rinaar, noticing that there was ruffled paper stashed in one of the drawers, thought to himself "He probably is in the vault... I'm not sure; I should check". For which reason he got up, and after confirming the time left, headed to the back of the bank. Straight from the main entrance, then left at the atrium, up to the second floor, right at the blocks, and then entering the elevator. "Take the elevator down to the second basement" repeated Rinaar under his breath, as he pressed an assortment of buttons in a specific order, after which he pressed the button marked "2B". Rinaar kept a blank face as he noted the floor number on the display of the elevator. The bell's ring marked the arrival of the elevator at its destination, and the opening of the elevator doors allowed Rinaar to enter the vicinity. Rinaar found one of his colleagues looking through a vault file. During the conversation, Rinaar was informed: "As you happen to be here, perchance you could glean information in 22.06.92". Rinaar nodded as he made his way through the labyrinth. The walls on both sides were covered with vaults, numbered in a specific order: the first number was the file number, the second showed how many vaults were below it, and the third number was how far the banker had to walk before he reached the correct vault. Rinaar had crossed ninety two vaults, and found the series he was looking for. He took the ladder and climbed five vaults and opened the sixth vault. He then took out the file numbered "twenty two". He opened the file, and skimmed through the details. Rinaar closed the file, stepped down from the ladder, and handed the file to his colleague. "I'll send instructions over to your desk for this file. I'll close everything down here and come upstairs. See you then." Rinaar was told. Rinaar, nodding and waving his colleague, took the elevator upwards. Rinaar reached his desk and, noting that his neighbor was on his way, looked at the lobby. The façade was a wonderful assortment of paintings of different eras, with some portraying the "Colonial Fort" age on one side, and the other showing the foundations being laid for the bank. His desk was under the atrium, where the walls on either side had photographs and paintings of the presidents of the bank. Rinaar was not bothered by the fact that all of them wore a specific type of hat; had an angry serious look on their face; and always looked into the distance rather than directly at the camera/painter. It did not matter, as Rinaar had received the instructions and relevant parcel from his colleague. He noted the instructions, and after clarifying certain details, Rinaar nodded and sat down. He looked at the lobby, and then went back to reading his book, "The Financial Accord for Vault Maintenance and Account Management".

Reading between the Lines

A book can take up space, and can also be very likely to suffer damage when doing so. The type of binding involved in the creation of each book was appreciated far more than it should be – it is a craft, a skill, and a tool. No more, no less. That was what Lebrius Punbell Lon Pamell thought as he was making his rounds around the book towers. These were his responsibility to monitor and to keep intact for whenever they were to be rented out. Punbell didn't mind – he had no personal history with these books, and ever since they had been procured by the library they only gained glancing interest. Punbell took note of those qualities as he took note of each book tower, having started his shift today at tower 84. He had noted the names of the book, and used the reference number to tally if they had been checked out. Punbell muttered the names of each book as he noted their names, humming in between as he searched and tallied from his list. One of the missing books – "The Financial Accord for Vault Maintenance and Account Management" – was noted in his list. "Need to send a mail on these soon as I finish tower 93" Punbell mentioned aloud, and took another book into his list – "Stop the Bez". Punbell was given company by the scratching of the pencil with the paper and clipboard; the soft rustling of trees; the rays of sunshine arriving from the corner of the library visible from tower 76, reflecting at his office; his own yawns; and the sound of his shoes tapping on the floor as he made his way to and fro in the library. Punbell, having reached tower 85, found that there were no books which warranted further action. Punbell walked through tower 93, turned left, walked straight passing towers 93 thru 71 on his left and towers 92 thru 72 on his right. His workstation faced tower 76, with a staircase heading upwards at a modest distance. Punbell sat down, and took out a folded paper out from one of the cabinet drawers of his workstation. There were four books with a white paper mark on his workstation. The mark had written on it "returned, noted and archived" and was stamped with a date. One of the books – "Niner Hotel: origins, history, myths and legends" – was recently returned. Punbell put the books on a side and, with a clear table, placed the unfolded paper. It had numerous crosses and dots on it, with the title reading "Helping Hand for the Library, seventh iteration". Punbell took out a pencil and then picked up the list of books he had made. Noticing that the list was unable to explain certain things, Punbell took out a directory, opened it adjacent to – but not on top of – the map, and started work. He noted the name of the book, and searched the directory. Whomever had checked out the book was marked on the map. This process took some time, but Punbell had been able to pin-point all the crosses from his list to the map. "It seems that the season ended early this year" thought Punbell, as he worked through the list once more, as a confirmation. Once reassured that the list was correct, and noted on the map, Punbell filled the directory, folded the map and then placed it as well as the list inside a brown letter envelope. He wrote on the envelope Checkout List, return dates included. He then stepped away from his desk, went up the staircase, and turned left. He passed by some book towers. They were all on his right side and were numbered 50 till 32; he reached the end of the hall where numerous envelope holders were present. He opened the envelope holder marked "Book Checkout", and put the envelope inside. Punbell walked back to his desk and took out another map, this time with the title "archival map for returned books". Punbell took out the directory and started the process of noting the addresses from where the books had been returned. Punbell had been asked about this process, especially from journalists who were fascinated by the library itself. Originally titled "The Honorable Library in memory of the family Külzirtaak", the full title was contracted to "The Honorable Library", until it was better known as "The Library". To most journalists and historians, these small details held special importance. Yet whenever they asked Punbell, he would promptly respond with silence... and a book wherein the answer to their question lay. Punbell picked up one of the books – "Lebrius Punbell Lon Pamell: a biography of a librarian" – noted the return date and address, as well as other details, mentioned and marked it in the map and put it alongside the completed books.

Checking In Before Twelve

Homaiz Lon Qaltir was idling the hours away in the verandah of his house, having consumed some fruits and a few glasses of apple juice. It was a Thursday morning, and he had deliberated upon his schedule with composed regard. Yesterday had been completely dedicated towards work – public dealing is enjoyable as a hobby, not as a vocation – but today, he knew he had time dedicated for self-reflection. In the company of trees, rustling their songs as the wind blew; the scent of flowers, fruits ("I will pluck the apples by the evening") and the fluttering of birds and buzzing of bees; Homaiz was living in the moment. Most of his friends would appraise him as an elderly gentleman of a bygone era. They also described him as "a dignified Mirtash amongst Külzirtaak". Unlike his friends, Homaiz did not indulge in such acts of fancy. He had firmly believed in principle, and now considered it a firmly rooted fact that loyalty to family and one's roots was much more important than self-indulgence. It was one of the reasons he worked everyday, and had late working hours on Thursday ("fulfilling my father's wish"). In truth, Thursday held importance for his father on the basis of how little time he had for family. Homaiz recalled with a sigh how his father would sit, and talk; Homaiz cherished those moments. "What of days long past, when time was a mere transit between events?" his father would ask, always before leaving to support his dream till his retirement: The Niner Hotel. Homaiz glanced at his watch, and nodded nonchalantly ("Right then, to work"). He took his plates and glasses into the house. It may have always sounded the same, but it was a rite of passage for anyone who understood how hotels worked. Homaiz, however, did not have such friends. They visited hotels; in fact most of them became friends with Homaiz only because other parents had frequented the Niner. The memory of one such interaction kept Homaiz preoccupied while he changed into his official attire. The sound of a music box distracted him. "For Homaiz, on his sixth birthday" was written on its base. "Funny thing about gifts; the sentiment remains, even if the memory is forgotten" was the only response in context to inquiries. To Hamza, the same could be said about hotels. Hamza and his friends had, almost out of principle, defined their lives around the Niner. There were the occasions of Birtash; the anniversary of the founding of the Niner was always a holiday to its oldest customers; the marriages of numerous family friends; perhaps the biggest gathering, and still an important but solemn occasion, was the funeral of his father. A picture from his school days – his father, proud, was gleaming as he sat in the center of the group with Hamza standing right behind him – as well as a handful few things were carefully cleaned and maintained. They were placed on what used to be the desk of Homaiz' father. That meant a lot to Homaiz. He smiled. His father had noted specific instructions regarding everything pertaining to the Niner, right down to the minutiae. It was a god-sent, and helped Homaiz immensely to get the Niner back on track. Homaiz opened the notebook, tallied the date with his calendar, and memorized the routine. With the exception of the line "When he wants to check in, open the box. Instructions have been provided in it" the rest was straight forward. Homaiz had observed that his father's diaries made constant reference to this one person, especially in the latter half of the entries. From what Homaiz could gather, this guest had been a regular in the Niner until a mutually kept secret – a disagreement which was discreetly handled, supposedly – had made the fellow leave. Hamza saw a picture of an old man; short, trimmed oiled hair; and a walking cane with the insignia of the Nine-Lines (a sign that he was an old member of the hotel) on his father's desk. However, the guest in question was not this gentleman. Regardless, Homaiz knew that the gentleman in question will probably check into the hotel today. Homaiz matted his hair with the same specific oils his father used, especially for Thursday, and sprayed the specific cologne meant for today. "Use the one marked 8.13.21" said the entry. Homaiz obliged ("Fulfilling my father's wish"). While applying the cologne, Homaiz noticed that it had a particularly difference scent than the ones he regularly applied. He noticed that it had a softer personality – it was more welcoming than the other colognes, almost in a parental tone rather than an institutional one. His own regular colognes were

Niner, through and through: the motto "Roots are the source to happiness" emitted from them. 8.13.21 reminded him of his house: the feeling of nostalgia, belonging, of a familiar place calling itself home. It had a word. Hamza's father used it when they would have dinner outside in the verandah, during spring. It then would follow up with one story or the other concerning Youth, which carried with them pearls of wisdom. Homaiz had one in mind as he locked the main entrance of his house: "The key to true happiness, is inanity". As he made his way to the gate, Homaiz gazed at the avenue. The Niner had been strategically located from his house with a unique premise: Convenience for the guest also applies to the host. People had easily forgotten that the house had been built first, not the hotel. The hotel was, in the eyes of its master, a hobby that grew into a vocation until it became his identity. As Homaiz locked the gate, the rustling of the leaves made him recall numerous memories and incidents. There was a saying "I willed a feast, so I had one; Birtash was and still is, about the same". Hamza continued to contemplate, as he made his way to work. It took him eight minutes from locking the gate to unlocking the entrance of the Niner; it was a mere fifteen minutes of setup everything after that. Reception, lobby, café and lights – always in that order. The Niner always welcomed guests; it always had a list of visitors who always came to stay. Some came because of the Niner brand: Homaiz recalled an entire book dedicated to how nine statues of nine princesses in nine rooms yet to be found had given the hotel its name. Some aspects about these myths were half true. It was true that his father had bought a nine layered doll set, and he had taken inspiration from it when he registered the name of the hotel. But the rumor about nine statues of nine princesses in nine rooms was brushed off as "creative liberties, albeit a well thought out one". Homaiz smiled. He remembered when the hotel had started and, after a brief testing period, discontinued a tour of the Hotel. Even as a failure, it fascinated a new generation of visitors. Around this time Homaiz had begun to take administration of the Niner, his father being semi-retired. While the old members acknowledged While the old members acknowledged and supported Hamza; and the middle tier had met Hamza's father but were more inclined towards Homaiz; the new generation was fascinated by Homaiz. His friends thought that Homaiz might not have continued his father's legacy had it not been for the naïve admiration of this new generation. In truth, Homaiz would have continued his legacy anyway. It was as much his investment as it was his father's. It was irreplaceable. The rustling of the trees seemed to agree with Hamza, nodding to the thought. As Hamza turned left from the avenue, and made his way past Colonial Point, he saw the gates to the Niner. A stately pair of redwoods bent forward, probably because of the wind, as though bowing to greet Homaiz. He acknowledged their greetings in return. Unlocking and then opening the gate, Homaiz proceeded forward to the reception, and completed his routine. There were others too... or so Homaiz thought. In the management of a hotel, the lower staff were less likely to be present, at least to Homaiz' recollection. He had a few fellows in the vicinity, so – like clockwork – the hotel was prepared for visitors. Homaiz informed his staff about their duties, and then walked to the reception. Homaiz opened the register, and looked through his log book for other pending tasks. Most of them only involved making sure select rooms had select items for select purposes. The most intriguing were the guests who came to visit the library and the bank – the former to discuss any new additions to their collection, the latter to make sure they can make the necessary transaction. "I should call Punbell and Raneer before the day ends" thought Homaiz. For all their quirks, they paid regularly and their history with the Niner made them invaluable. One of these rooms – 6.35 – was readied accordingly. A specific package was included in the cupboard next to the bed. It was wrapped in brown paper and was signed and confirmed with a card saying "It was from a time long past.... Well, you know what it is. The importance of it at any rate". Homaiz, out of habit, checked to see if all the utilities in the room were in working order and were well maintained. He was satisfied. Homaiz left the room after shutting the lights off and locking the door. He made his way back to the reception, noticing that the stairs had not been tidied properly. He kept it in mind and, upon returning to the reception he rung the bell. He let the lower staff

know of this observation and had him respond to it. Homaiz opened the box as per his father's instructions. He looked through the contents, read through the letter included in it, sighed, locked it, locked it (after removing the letter) and returned it in its place ("Fulfilling my father's wish"). Homaiz returned to the reception to make the requisite calls to Punbell and Raneer.

The Last Winds of Autumn Bliss

There is a certain charm found in a change of seasons – whether it is from melancholy to bliss to dismay to indifferent, they all serve their purpose in one's emotional state. In school, it certainly is claimed to be the case amongst students regardless of age. There comes the argument of "my parents don't understand", or "the adults don't listen to us", which is silly and doesn't hold much ground on its own. A gentleman of advanced age, Qin Laraiez, stopped reading the editorial immediately after the last sentence, took hold of a pen, and started correcting it. This was an editorial in a newspaper describing school children performance using various indicators. As Qin, Laraiez had taken particular note of his school and how it performed. Even though it was a weekend, Laraiez still preferred coming to his office and making sure everything was in running order. It was also convenient for him since he could look into the administrative affairs without interruptions. He had a backlog represented by the pile of papers on the "Pending completion" box on his desk, which he had decreased in the few hours since he had started working in the office. He had taken the newspaper with him from his house, walking distance from the school. He found it was a soothing experience, especially with a cup of hot chocolate, biscuits, and some Yiveliz. "I should get in touch with Elias about this" Laraiez thought to himself, as he looked at a report submitted in the "Pending Completion" box. He made his comments with a red pen on the report, and when he reached the end page put it in the "Administration Outbox". The sound of leaves rustling gave him company, and helped pass the time. His office had a prosperous view of the school playground – a lush and vibrant expanse of land which, although having some small hills, was a pleasant sight. During school days, it would be vibrant with the sound of boys and girls, which was not always good news for the administration. Some of the students had a reputation for causing significant trouble, and often times were prone to ganging up and bullying whomever they wished regardless of gender. "Equal opportunity leads to equal rights" was one of their common excuses whenever the Qin had to resolve issues in which they were involved. Laraiez, however, had noted that the number of such incidents had decreased since he took up the mantle. If anything, these same students would visit him before heading home, to thank him and share their appreciation of his administration – none of them, even when subtly asked, would provide suggestions or share concerns to be handled by the administration. Laraiez had his ways: he held a report sharing the current situation of each student in the school inclusive of what they required help in, what they had improved upon, and what were their prospects. The report had been compiled slowly and steadily by the administration, since none of the students would open up to them either directly or indirectly. Laraiez found that it helped him as Qin – "A quiet person is like poison, killing slowly and without suspicion" had been his rationale for identifying and adapting the rules and regulations of the school. It didn't come as a surprise why he had been appreciated by students. Laraiez put the report in the "Completed" box and proceeded to look at the numerous vouchers and bills submitted for his approval. Laraiez had taken them into account, divided them according to vouchers, bills, fines, and events. Vouchers were then put in the "School Income" folder, which had been started for submission into the bank; Bills were then taken into account based on justification to which he either wrote "Sanctioned" or "Not Sanctioned" providing his signature alongwith; there had been no fines; events composed of the school activities to show what the students had achieved. This time there had been six events: a play titled "Father always loved chocolates: a comedy"; a science fair; a three day event dedicated to board games; and a trip to the Library. The library trip had five reports attached alongside from the teachers involved, who shared what books had been read by the students, as well as lessons learnt and recommendations for future trips. Laraiez found it fascinating that the students kept such good behavior while in a library – the one place they could visit without the need for a trip, was fascinating for all of them in terms of the history of the place, as well as its librarian Lebrius Punbell. Laraiez and Punbell had been students from the same series of

training programs, where Punbell trained to become a Lebrius while Laraiez trained to become a Qin. Laraiez opened a folder in which was written “Confidential reference file” and read through the document. He nodded while reading, as the tea, biscuits, and Yiveliz were placed at the corner of his desk. Laraiez got up from his desk, went to a file cabinet and took out a file from the “R-U” drawer. He compared the findings from this file, with the confidential reference file he was reading. He checked the newspaper for the date and wrote something on his diary. Laraiez took out a paper and wrote a memo on it, which he placed in an envelope and placed it on the desk of the reception with a sticknote: “For your reference”. Laraiez placed the confidential reference file in one of his desk drawers. He was nearly finished with his pending completion box, having only three more tasks to finish up. He decided to have his break first, while reading the editorial further.